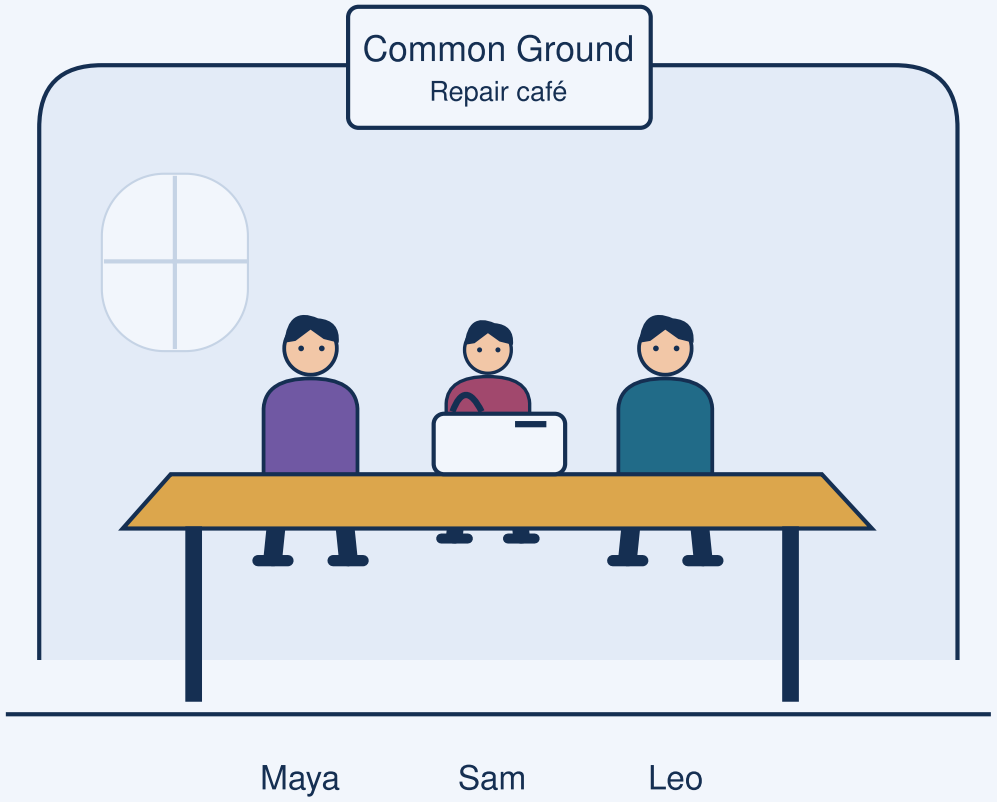
Maya arrives late. The room has already decided why.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

Leo is assigning the opening shift. What is his most informative next move?

A Ask Maya about today and check her availability.

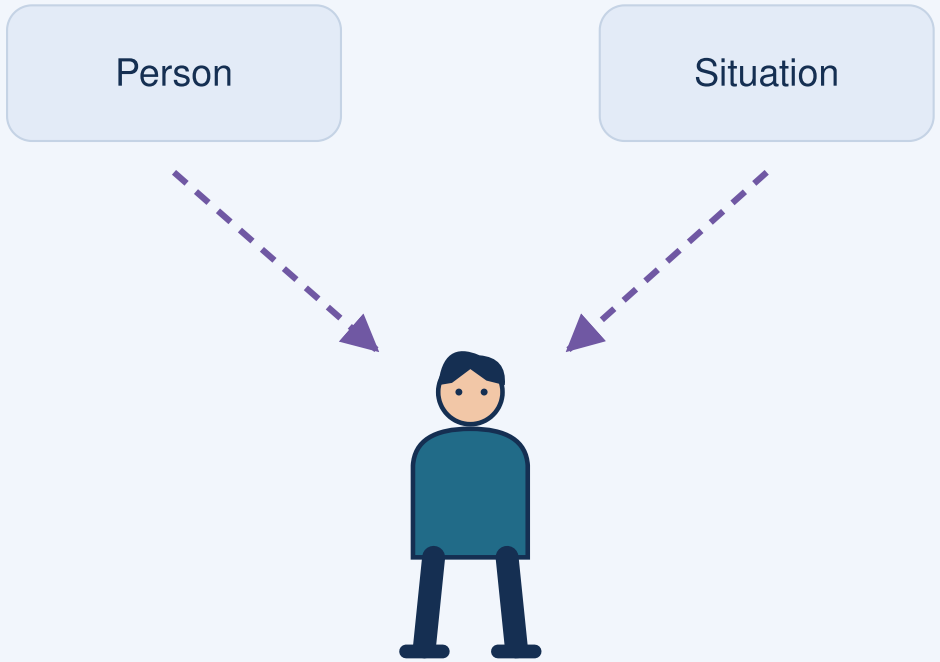
B Use today’s lateness as the main sign of reliability.

C Ignore today and assume she will arrive on time.

Suggested answer: A. He can investigate the obstacle and plan the shift without pretending the lateness did not matter.

Behavior has more than one author.

- Person: habits, values, skills
- Situation: constraints, roles, incentives
- Interaction: a setting affects people differently

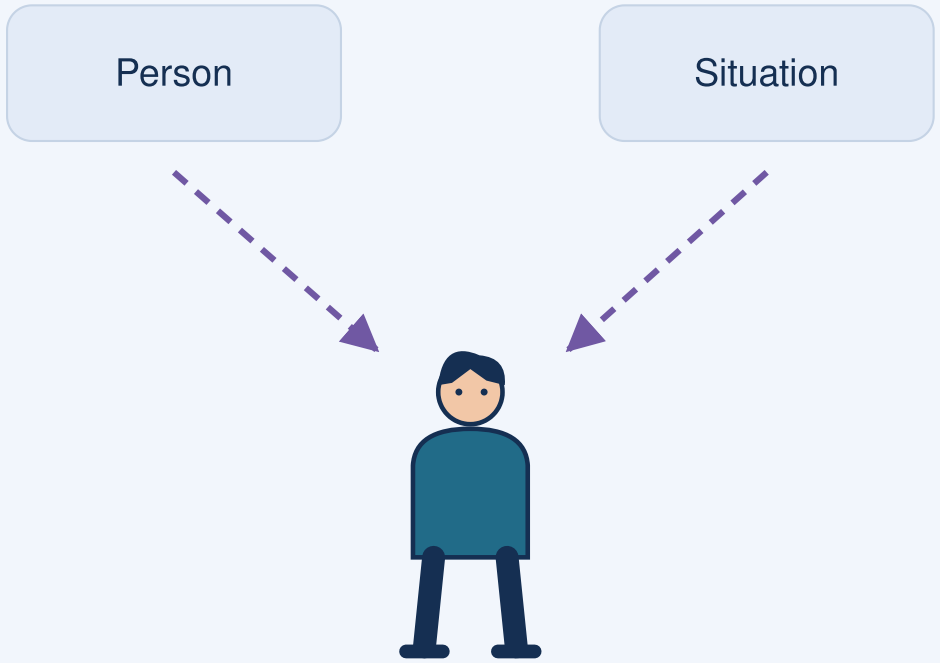


Behavior emerges in context.

Person and situation both contribute to behavior.

Observation is not explanation.

- Observed: Maya arrived after the start.
- Inferred: Maya does not care.
- Test: ask what changes across situations.

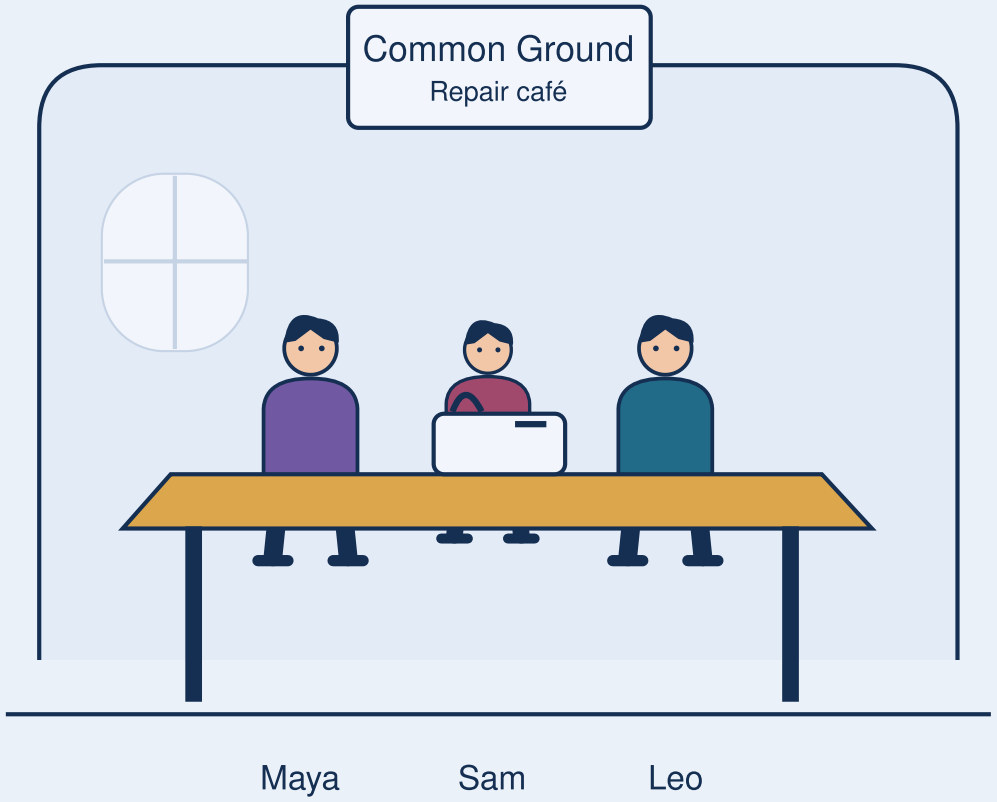


Behavior emerges in context.

Person and situation both contribute to behavior.

What can we really conclude?

Attribution studies describe patterns in judgment, not a law that character never matters. Repeated behavior across varied settings is more informative than one episode. Named effects such as actor–observer differences depend on the judgment and design. Do not turn every bias label into a universal rule or a diagnosis of someone else’s mind.



Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

A volunteer misses shifts only when the bus service is suspended. What should you test?

A Whether personality alone predicts attendance.

B Whether another travel plan improves attendance.

C Whether the missed shifts can be deleted.

Suggested answer: B. Changing the suspected barrier gives useful evidence while keeping expectations clear.

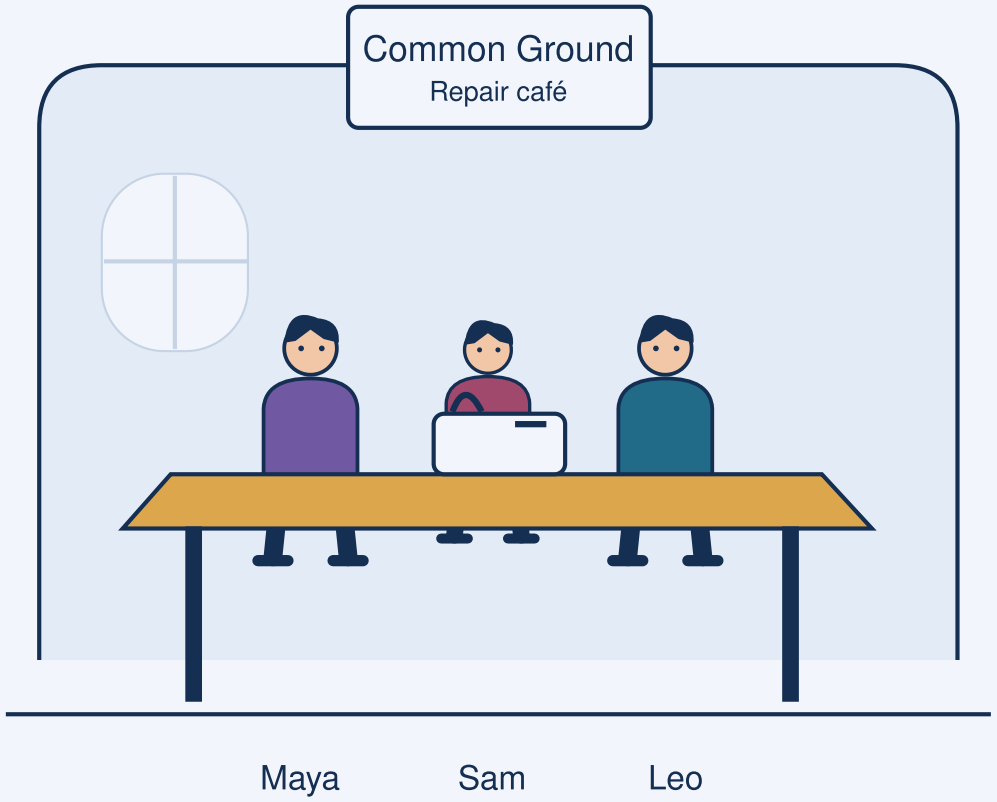
Close your notes. Explain it.

> Explain observation versus attribution.

> What would strengthen a personal explanation?

1. An observation records an action; an attribution proposes its cause.

2. A recurring pattern across varied circumstances, after examining plausible alternatives.

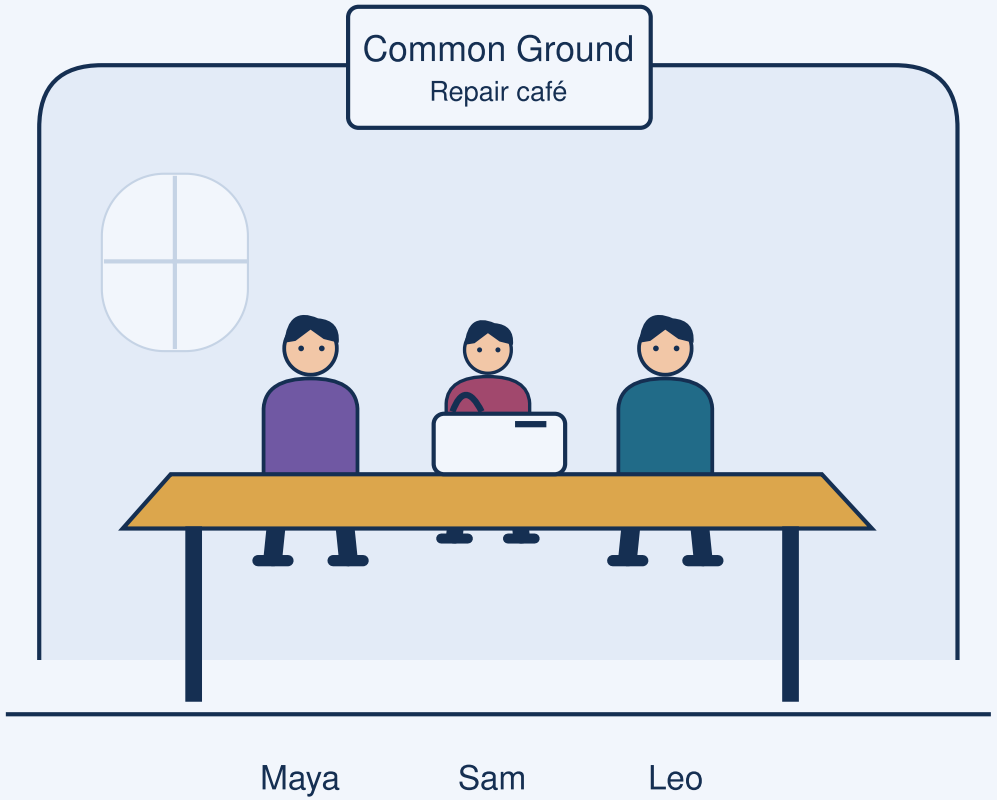


Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Choose a mildly frustrating encounter. Write the action, your first interpretation, two alternatives, and one respectful question that could clarify it.

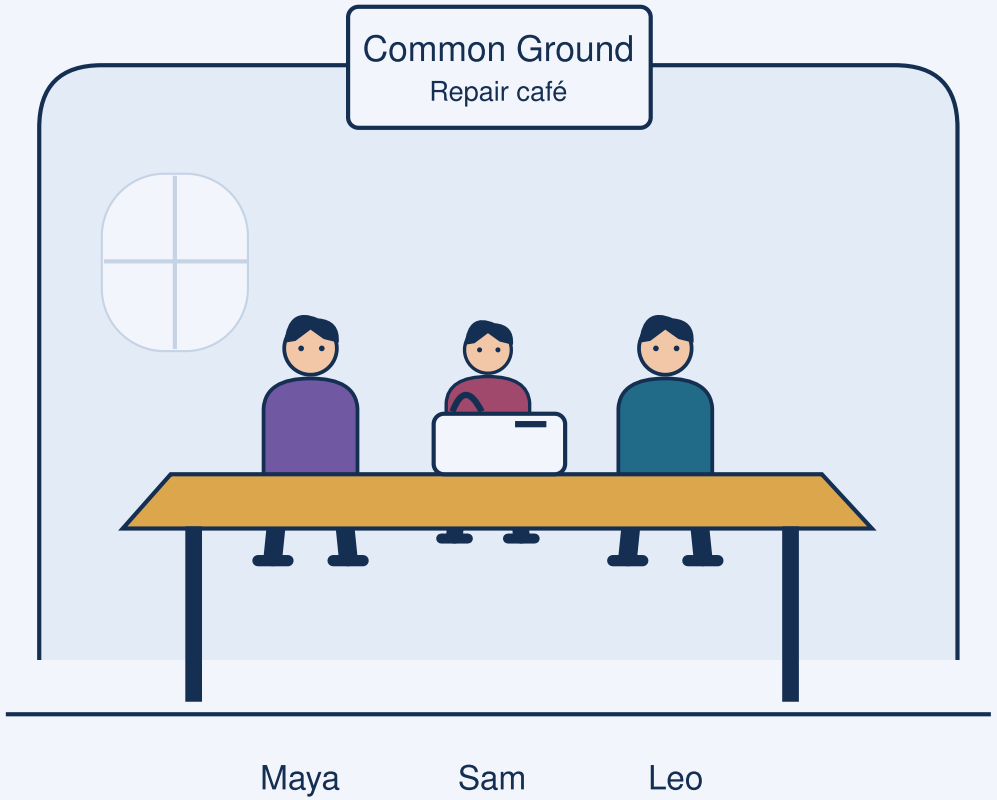
Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

A brighter poster. More visitors. A cause?

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

Which statement fits Leo’s evidence?

A The poster caused the increase.

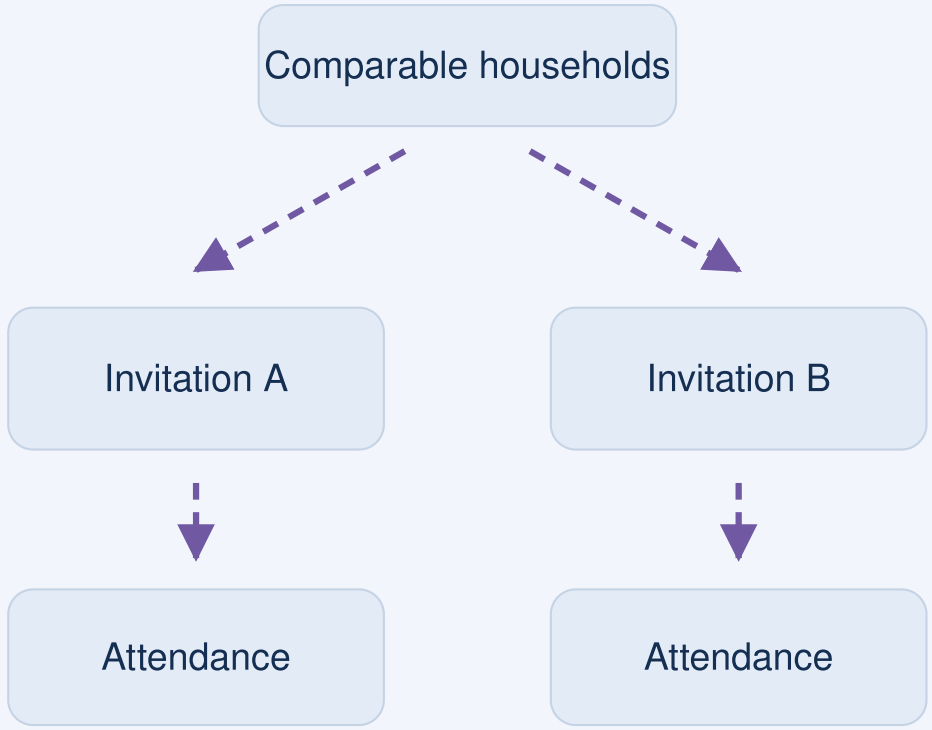
B The poster had no effect.

C Attendance rose; several causes remain possible.

Suggested answer: C. This preserves the observation without claiming to isolate a cause.

Comparison makes a claim testable.

- Correlation: things vary together.
- Confounding: another factor may explain the pattern.
- Random assignment: allocate conditions by chance.

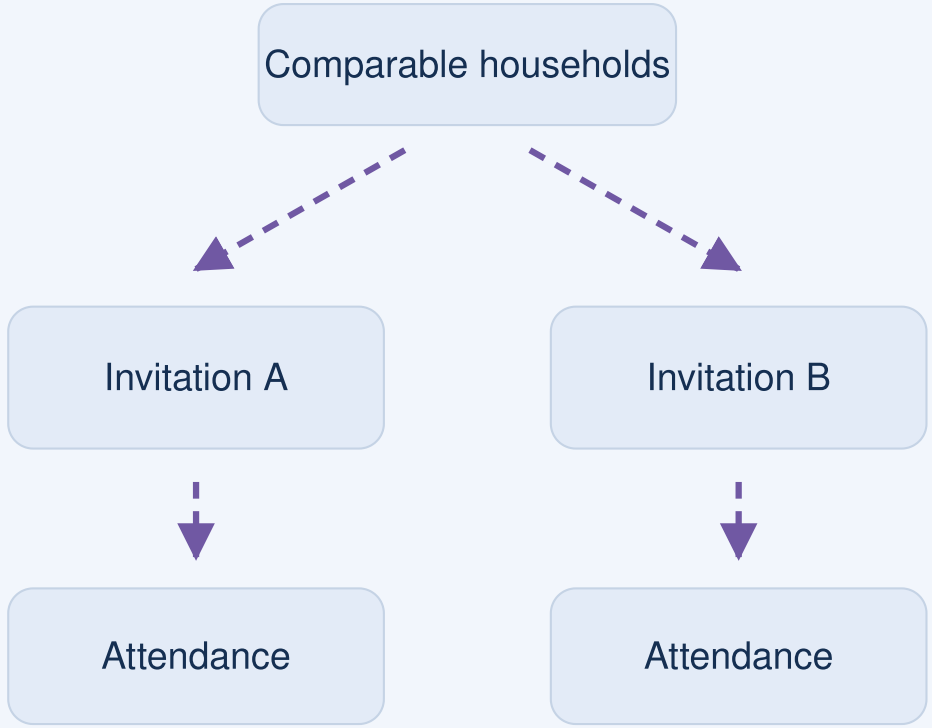


Allocate by chance. Compare like with like.

Random assignment supports a fairer comparison.

Ask how much—and how uncertain.

- Define the outcome before looking.
- Report the size of the difference.
- Examine uncertainty, missing data, and the sample.

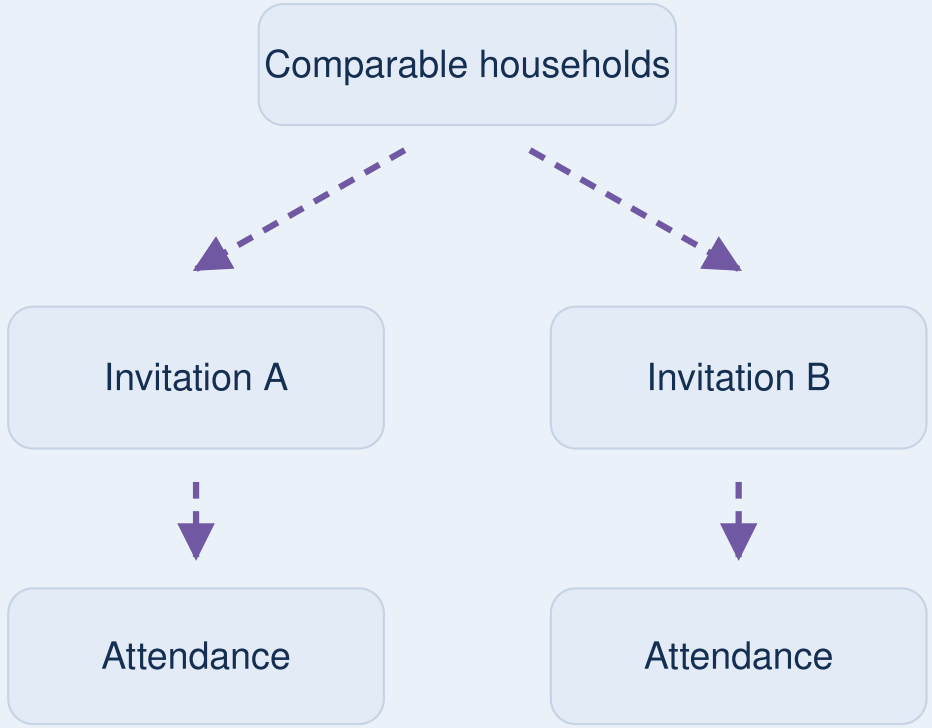


Allocate by chance. Compare like with like.

Random assignment supports a fairer comparison.

What can we really conclude?

Replication examines how dependable a finding is across repeated tests. Preregistration records planned methods and analyses before results are known, reducing some opportunities for selective reporting. It cannot rescue a poor design. Larger samples improve precision; transparent materials and independent tests help others evaluate the claim. A memorable study is a starting point, not a final verdict.



Allocate by chance. Compare like with like.

Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Which invitation comparison is strongest?

A Design A in winter; design B in summer.

B Randomize designs for one event; define attendance in advance.

C Design A for existing fans; design B for newcomers.

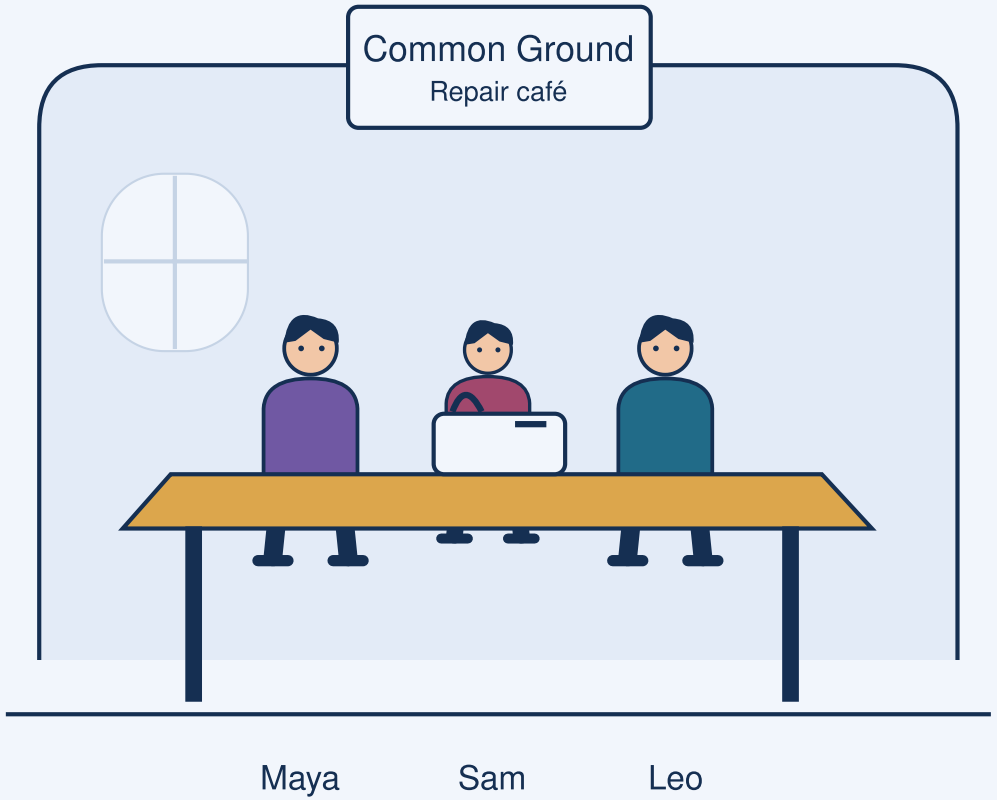
Suggested answer: B. This improves comparability. Also check whether households share invitations.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> How does assignment differ from sampling?

> Why is before-and-after evidence insufficient?

1. Assignment allocates conditions; sampling selects people.
2. Other conditions can change over time and produce the same pattern.

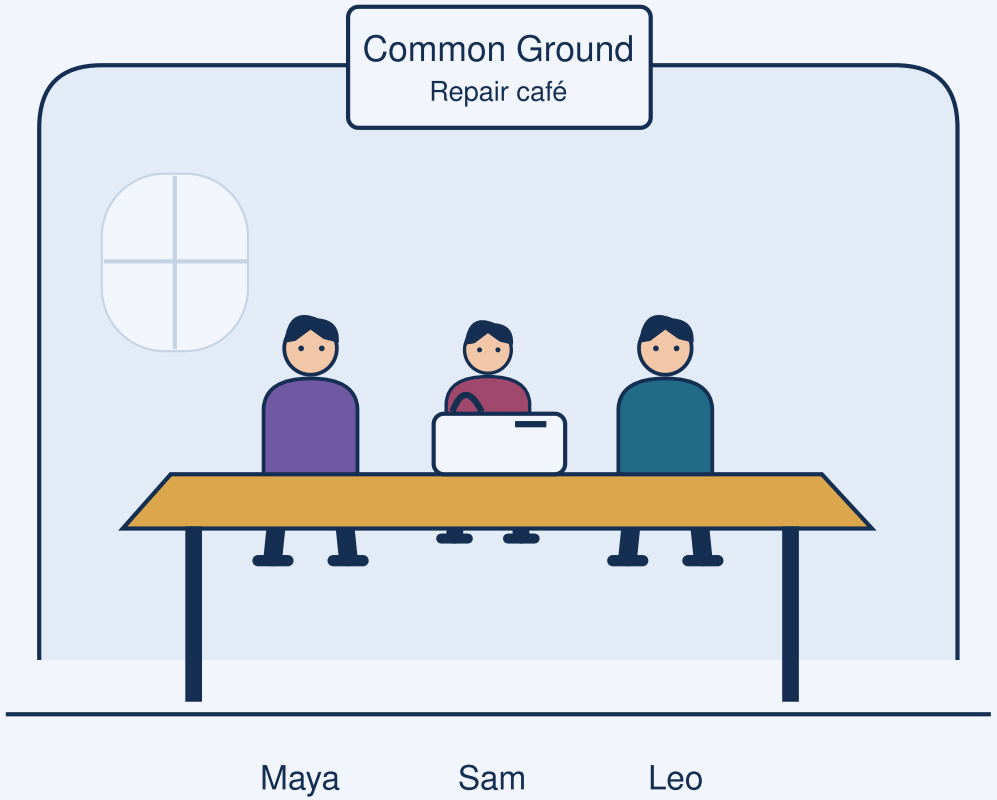


Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Find an everyday causal claim. Name its outcome, one competing explanation, and a feasible comparison. State whose behavior the result would represent.

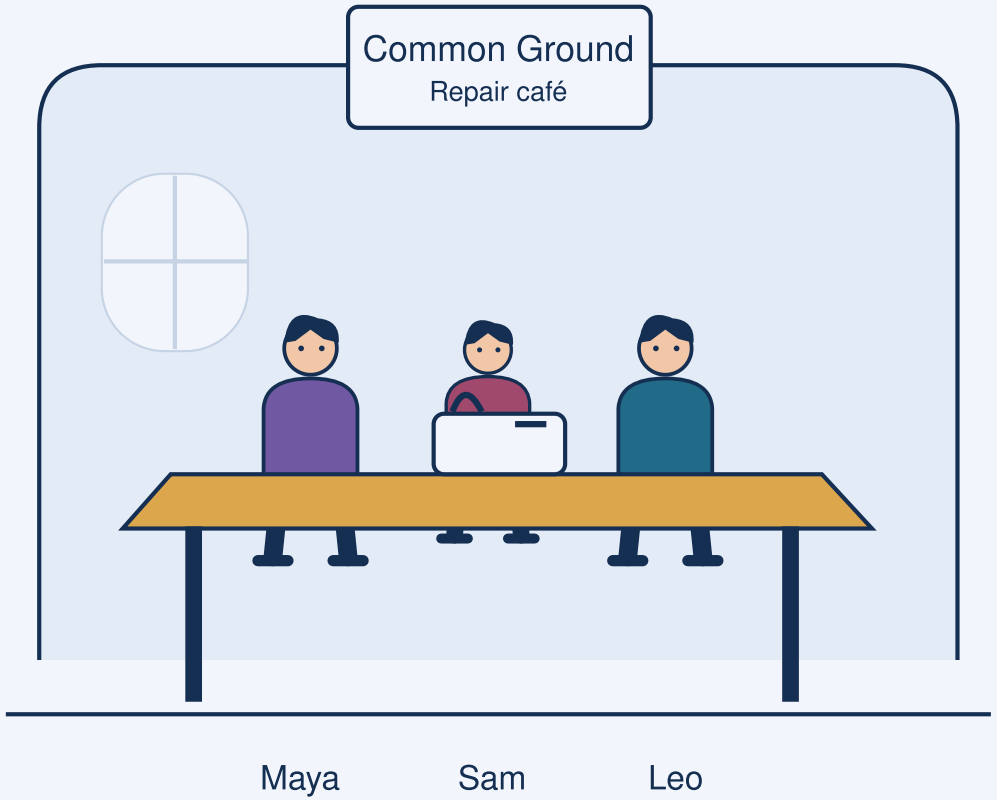
Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

One broken toaster becomes “they always break.”

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

What most improves the estimate of repeat failures?

A A detailed account of the worst failure.

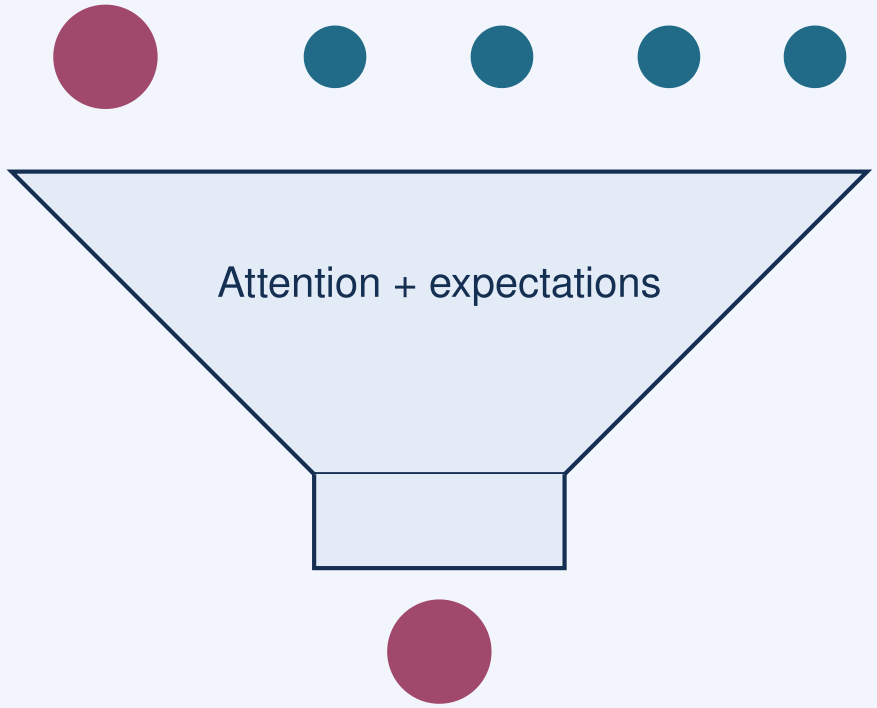
B Failures divided by comparable completed repairs.

C A vote on whose impression feels realistic.

Suggested answer: B. The denominator makes the cases interpretable; consistent follow-up still matters.

Memorable is not the same as common.

- Availability: accessible examples shape judgment.
- Base rate: how frequent is it overall?
- Selection: which cases reach your attention?

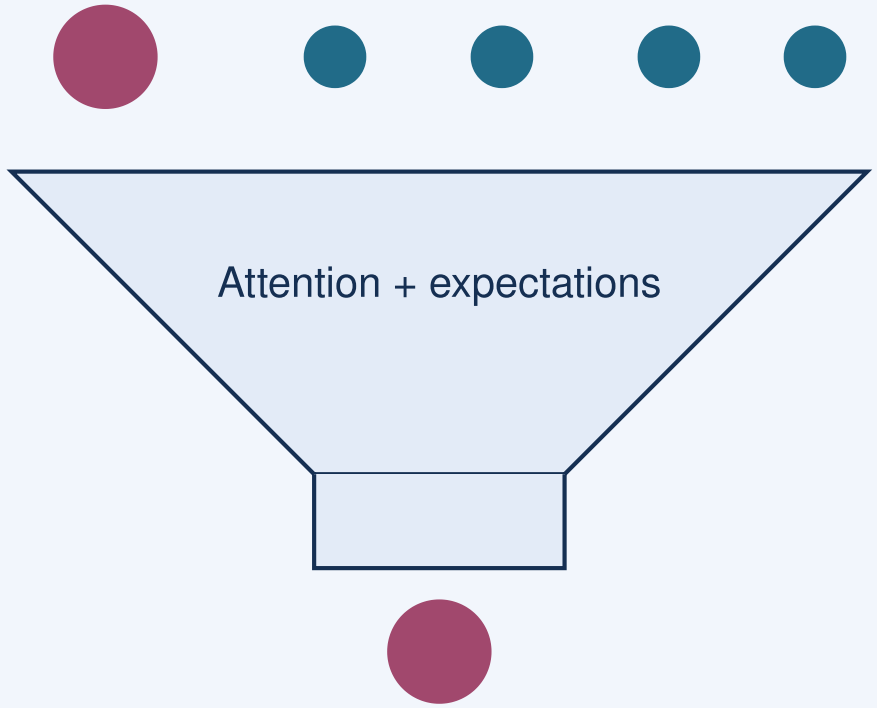


What reaches us is a selected sample.

Attention and expectations select the evidence we notice.

Beliefs can filter their own evidence.

- Notice which evidence you seek.
- Separate interpretation from the record.
- Ask what would change your mind.

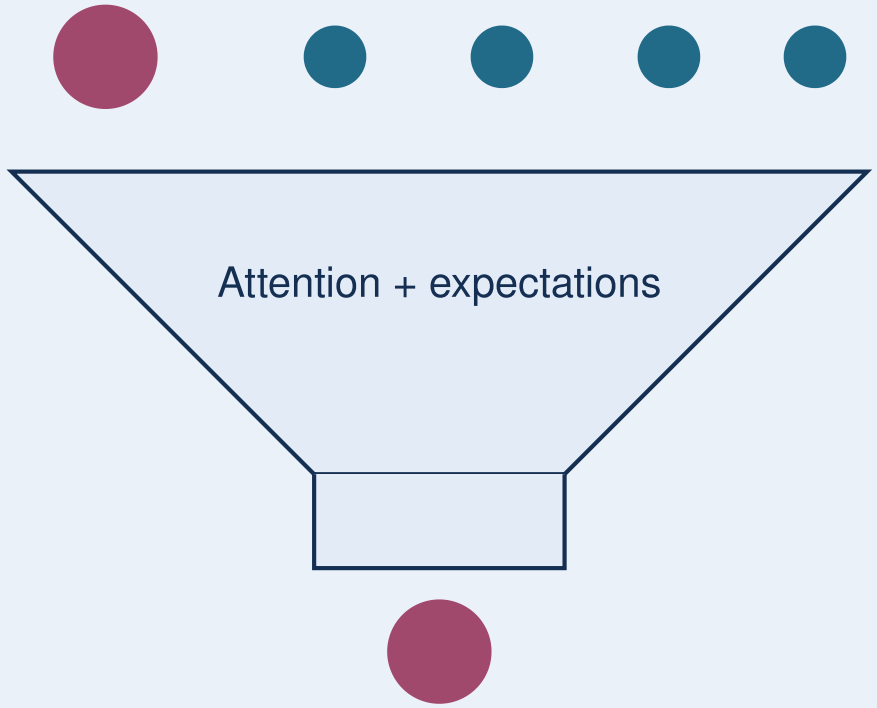


What reaches us is a selected sample.

Attention and expectations select the evidence we notice.

What can we really conclude?

A bias name does not establish why one person made one judgment. To distinguish availability from accurate expertise, compare the judgment with relevant data. Corrective strategies are aids, not immunity. Experts also need feedback, representative records, and procedures that permit their expectations to be wrong. Personal reflection alone cannot replace those conditions.



What reaches us is a selected sample.

Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Leo thinks evening sessions fail. Which question best challenges his belief?

A Which evenings went badly?

B Who agrees that evenings are a poor idea?

C What outcomes would make us conclude evenings work?

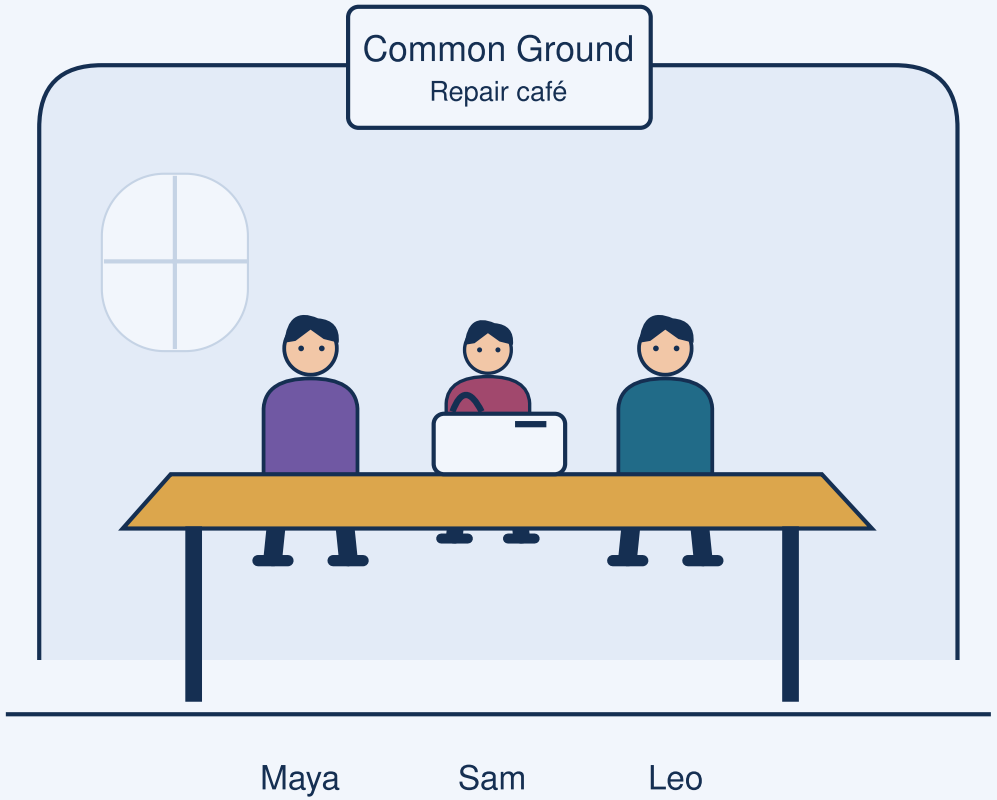
Suggested answer: C. Defining possible disconfirmation makes the belief testable.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Why does a vivid case need a denominator?

> When can an availability shortcut be useful?

1. Without the total of comparable cases, frequency is unknown.
2. When accessible examples reliably represent the relevant events.

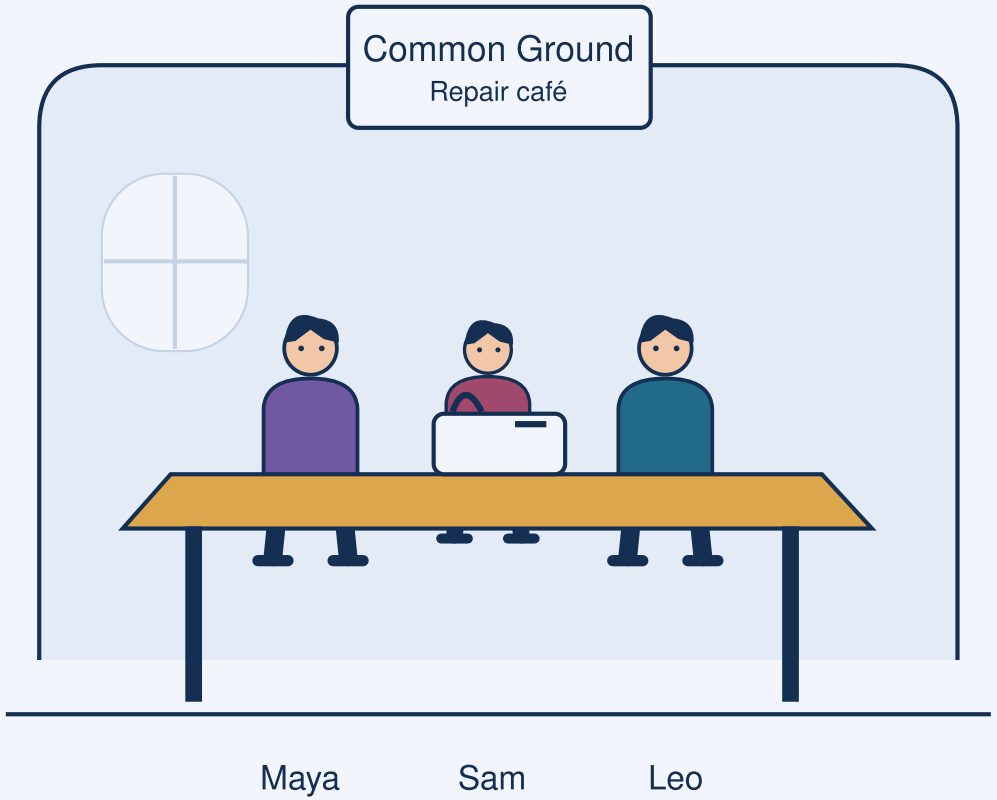


Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Keep a small record of one everyday prediction for a week. Include successes and failures. Avoid collecting private information about others. Compare the whole record with your first impression.

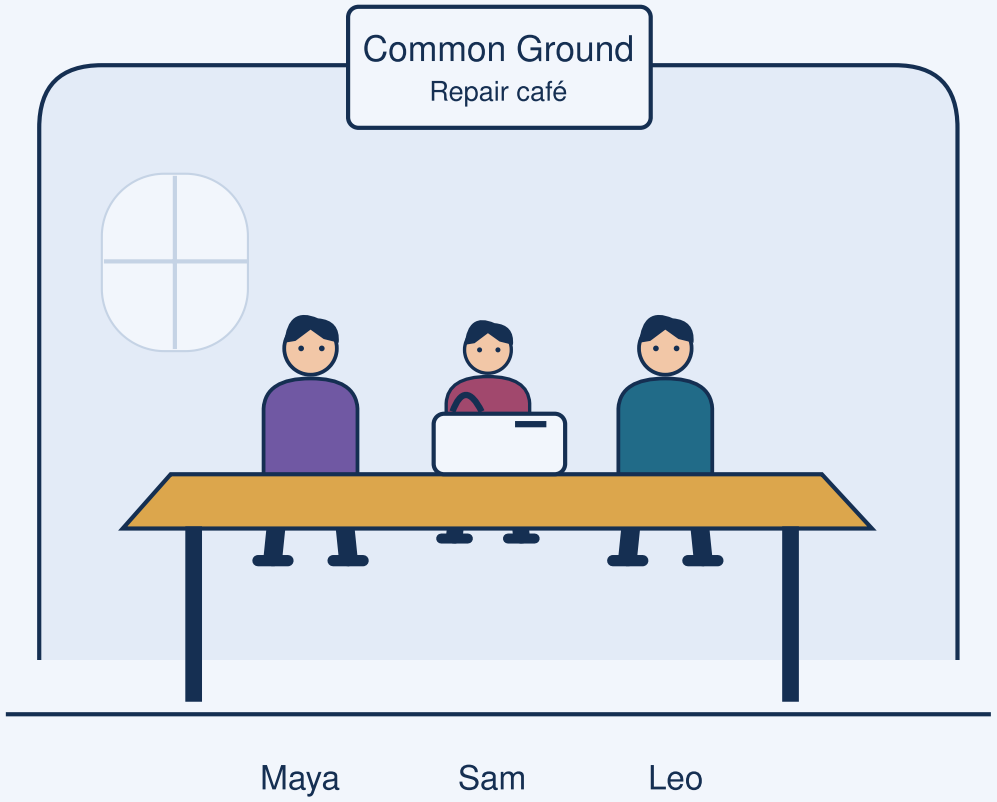
Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

“I chose it” quietly becomes “it must be right.”

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

What makes honest revision easier?

A Review failures and compare options afresh.

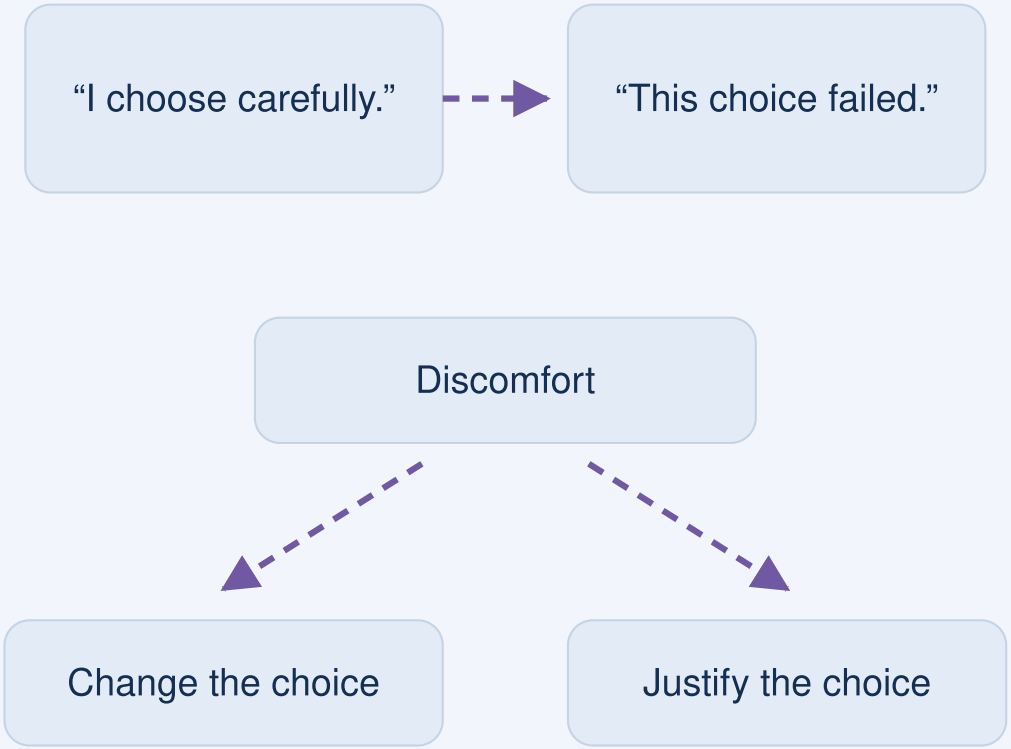
B Remind Maya that a competent coordinator would know better.

C Keep the system until the investment feels worthwhile.

Suggested answer: A. This makes the decision about outcomes rather than defending identity.

Inconsistency can feel uncomfortable.

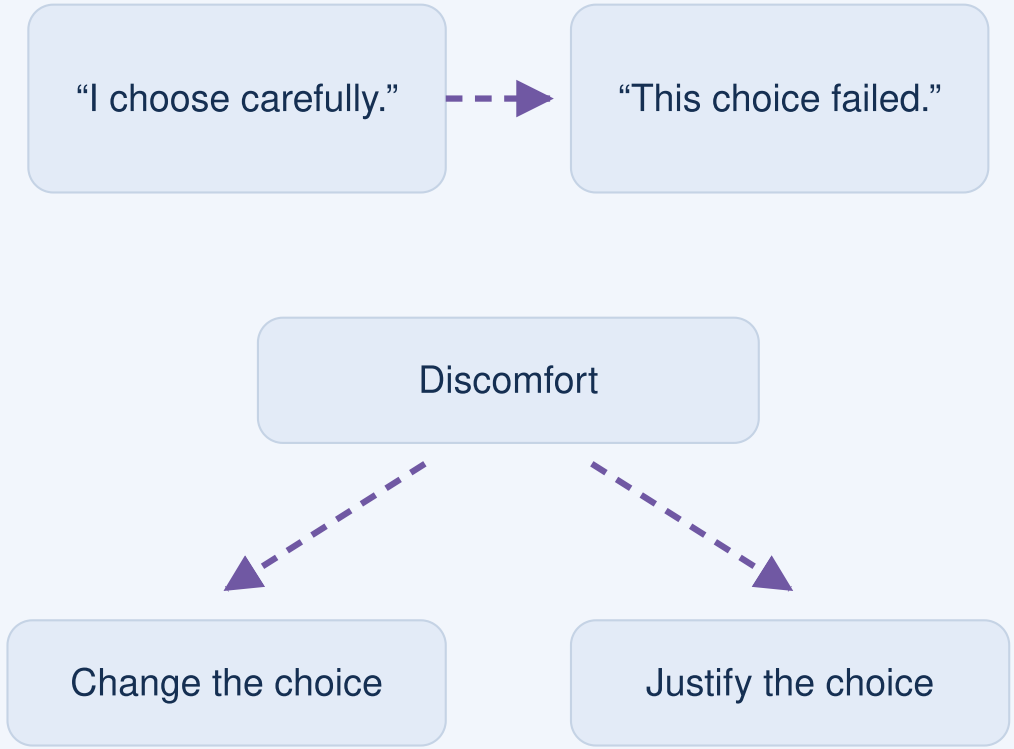
- “I make careful decisions.”
- “This decision is causing problems.”
- Repair the action—or reinterpret the evidence.



Inconsistency can lead to revision or justification.

Give the future a fresh vote.

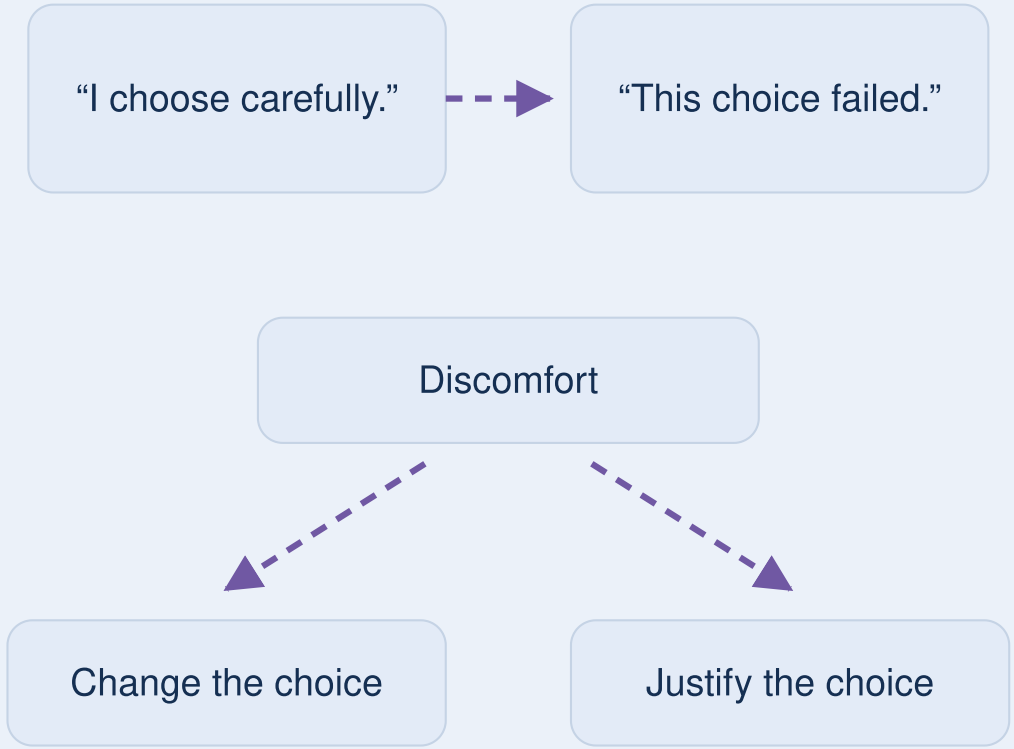
- Past cost: already incurred.
- Future cost: still avoidable.
- Compare consequences from today.



Inconsistency can lead to revision or justification.

What can we really conclude?

Specific dissonance demonstrations have uneven evidence. Vaidis and colleagues' preregistered 2024 multilab replication did not support the primary predicted high-choice versus low-choice attitude difference in one induced-compliance paradigm. This challenges the tested procedure. It neither confirms every dissonance claim nor disproves every version of the theory. Keep the influential framework separate from confidence in a particular demonstration.



Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Switching costs £100; keeping the tool costs £300 in future support. Benefits are equal. What matters?

A The large fee already paid.

B The lower avoidable future cost of switching.

C Only the emotional discomfort of switching.

Suggested answer: B. Under the stated assumptions, £100 is less than £300. Real choices also compare risks.

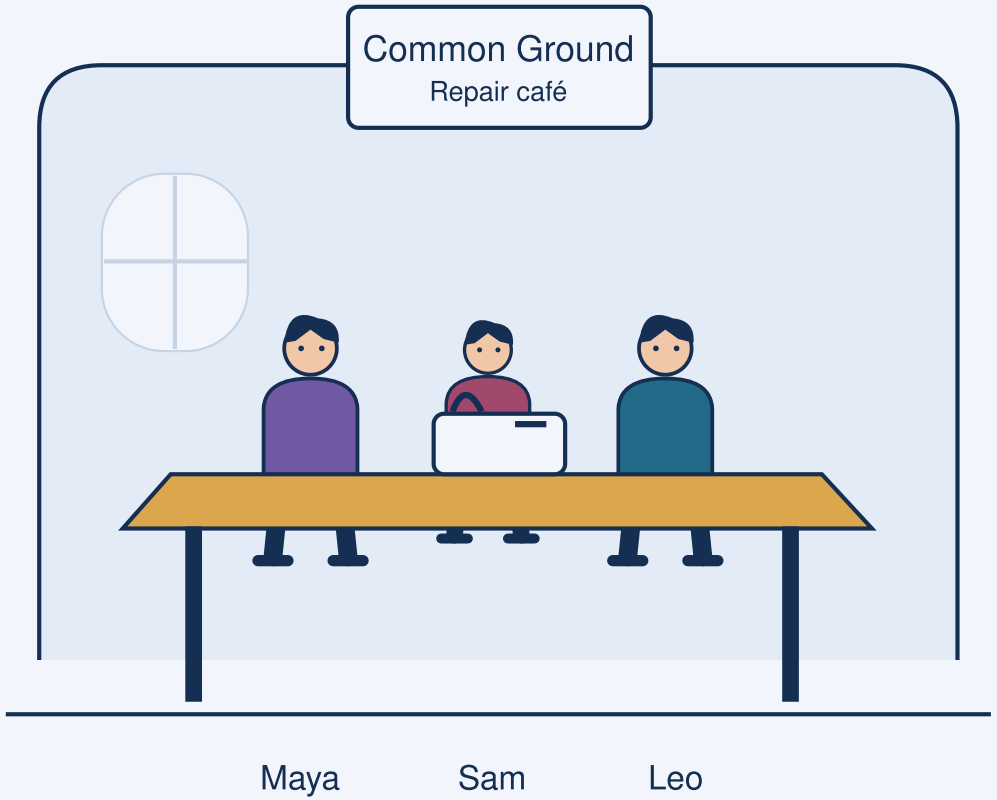
Close your notes. Explain it.

> Name two ways to reduce dissonance.

> When can a past investment still matter?

1. Change behavior or belief, or add a justification; context affects the response.

2. When it changes future consequences, such as switching costs or usable skills.

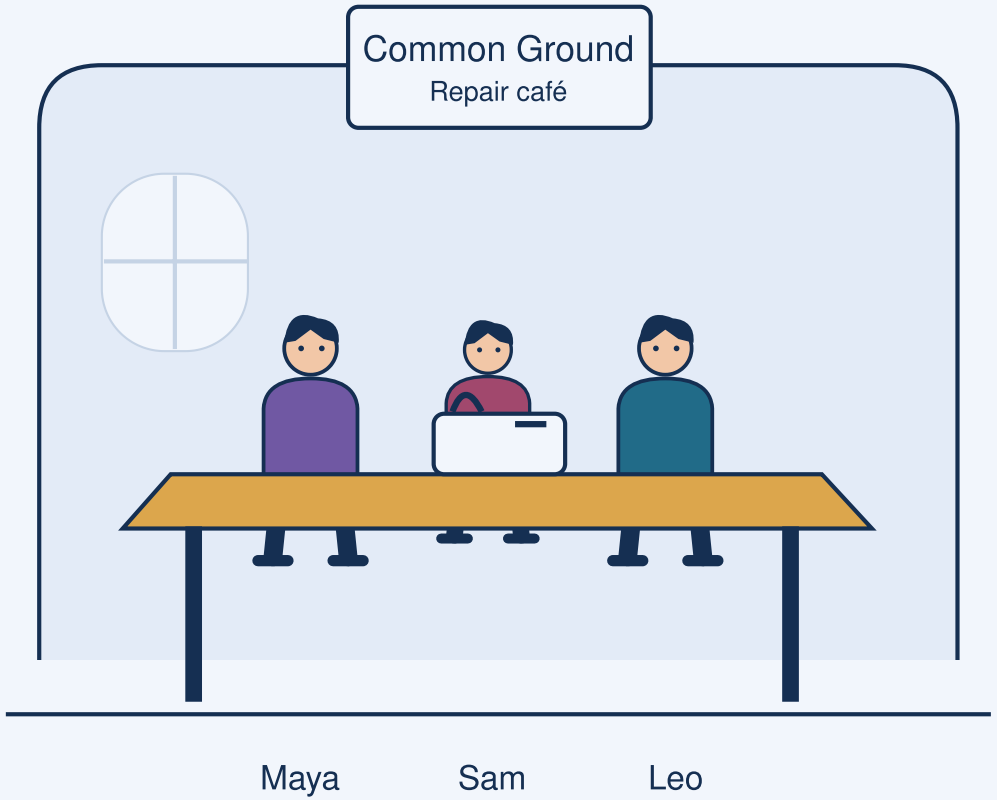


Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Revisit a small commitment you can change. List the future benefits and avoidable costs of continuing or stopping. Write a sentence that permits correction without attacking your character.

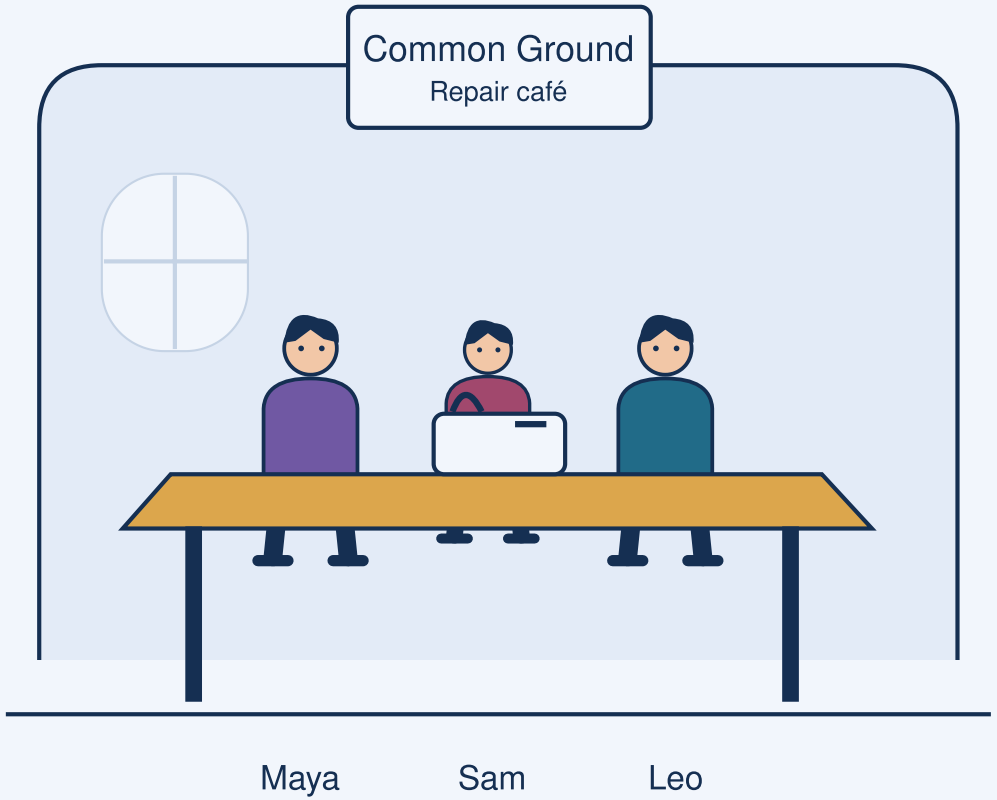
Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Everyone says yes. Has everyone agreed?

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

What could reveal concerns before discussion?

A Have the chair announce the preferred answer.

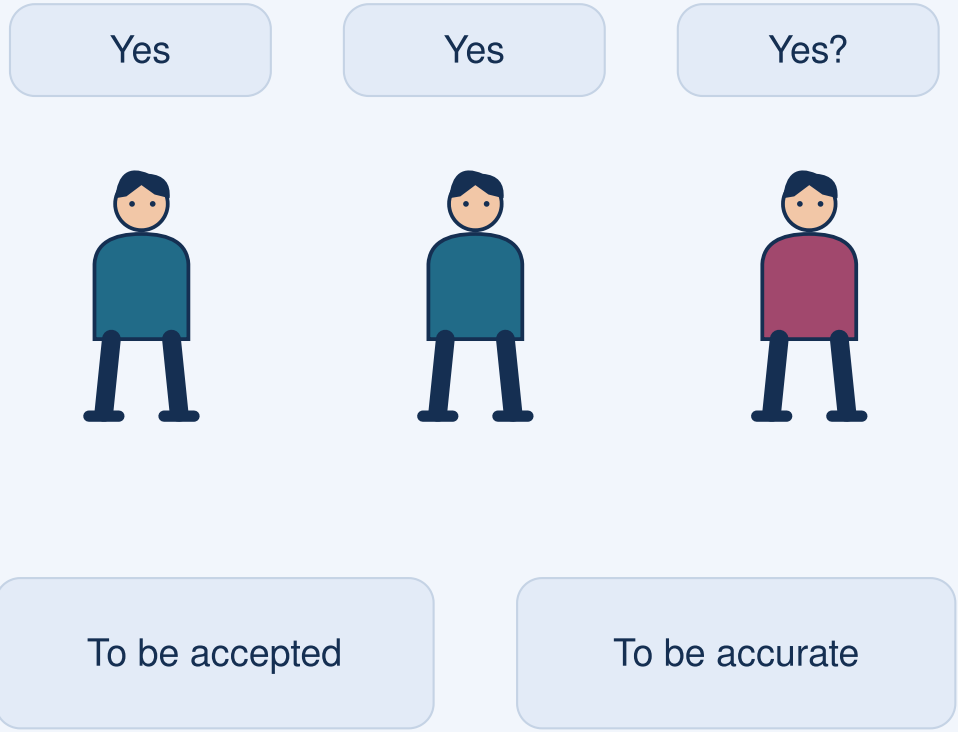
B Collect independent written judgments first.

C Ask only experienced members to speak.

Suggested answer: B. Independent responses make public agreement less necessary.

Two reasons to follow a group.

- Informational: they may know better.
- Normative: I want acceptance.
- Public agreement can differ from private belief.

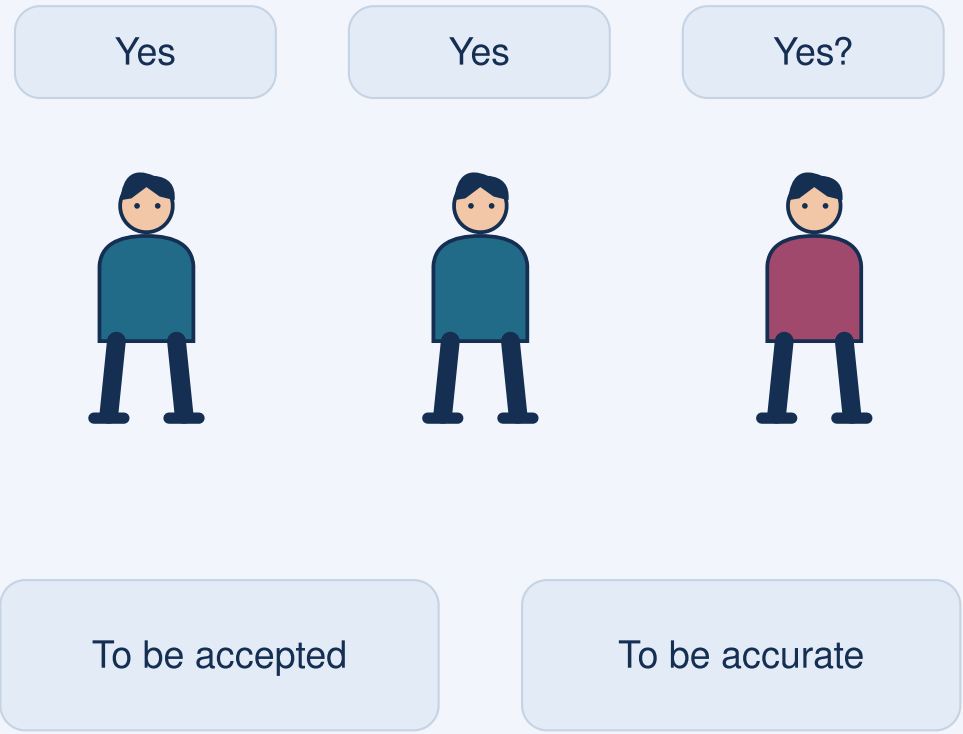


The same answer can have different motives.

Public agreement can reflect acceptance or information.

Authority changes the pressure.

- Compliance: responding to a request.
- Obedience: responding to an authority’s order.
- Make stopping and questioning possible.

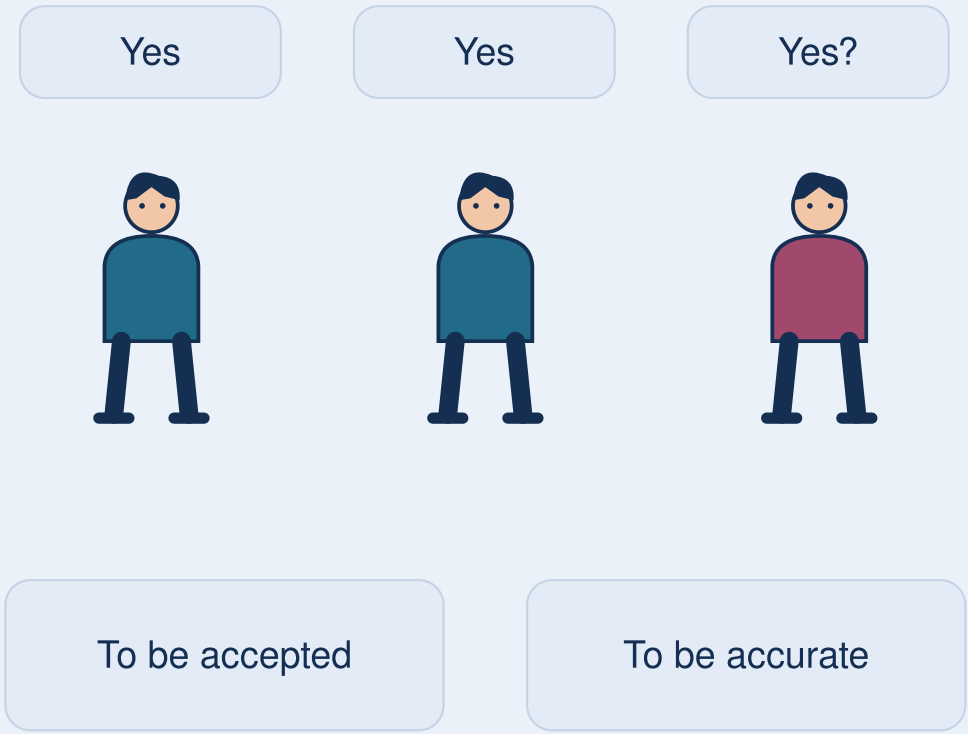


The same answer can have different motives.

Public agreement can reflect acceptance or information.

What can we really conclude?

Asch’s line-judgment studies examined majority influence in an artificial task. Milgram’s studies examined apparent authority in a highly structured setting. Their methods, ethics, and interpretation matter. They offer evidence about conditions of influence, not universal population obedience rates. Famous demonstrations should not be treated as proof that harmful conduct is inevitable.



The same answer can have different motives.

Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

The chair requests bypassing a required check. Which process helps?

A Let the first confident person decide.

B Allow anonymous complaints afterward.

C Pause and use an agreed safety escalation route.

Suggested answer: C. A clear route makes questioning possible while the decision still matters.

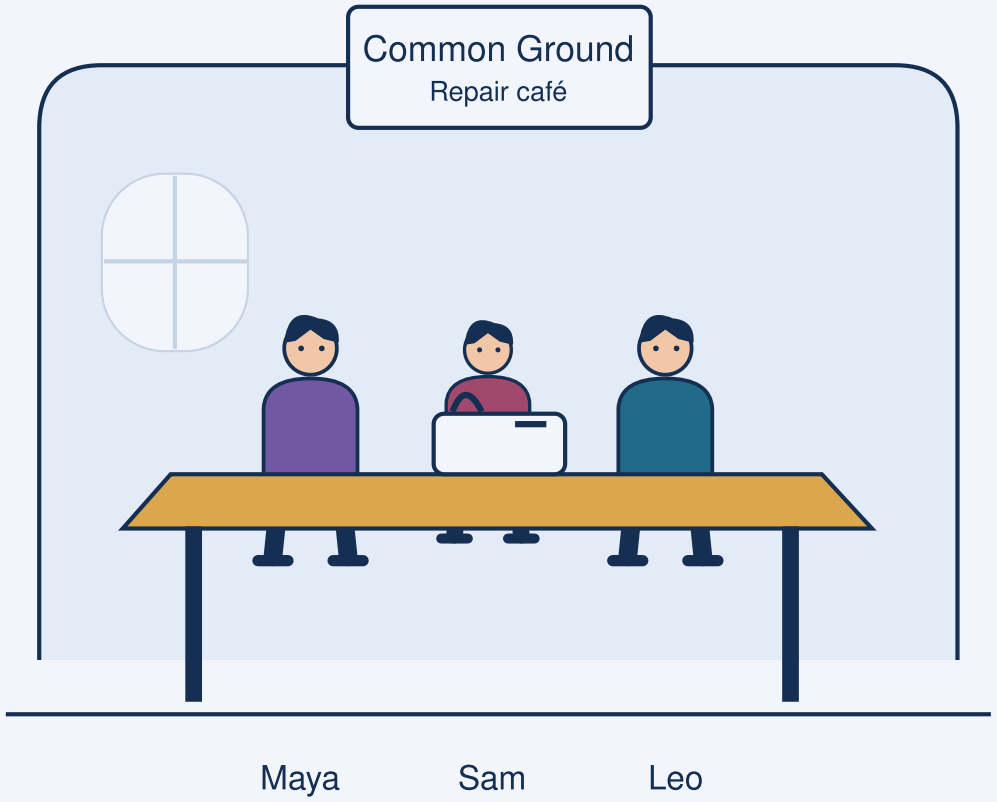
Close your notes. Explain it.

> Distinguish normative and informational influence.

> Why can public agreement overstate private agreement?

1. Normative concerns acceptance; informational treats others as evidence.

2. People suppress doubts, copy early answers, or infer that others have checked.

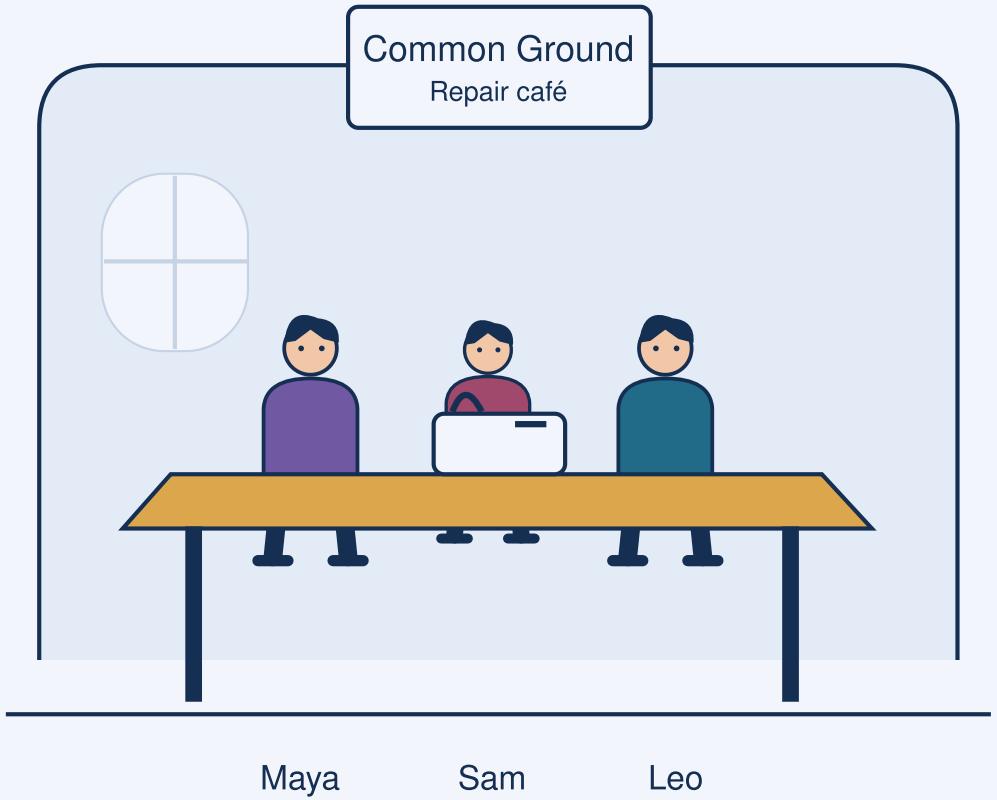


Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

For an agreed, low-stakes group choice, have everyone write a view before discussion. Compare the range of initial reasons with what a show of hands might have revealed.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.

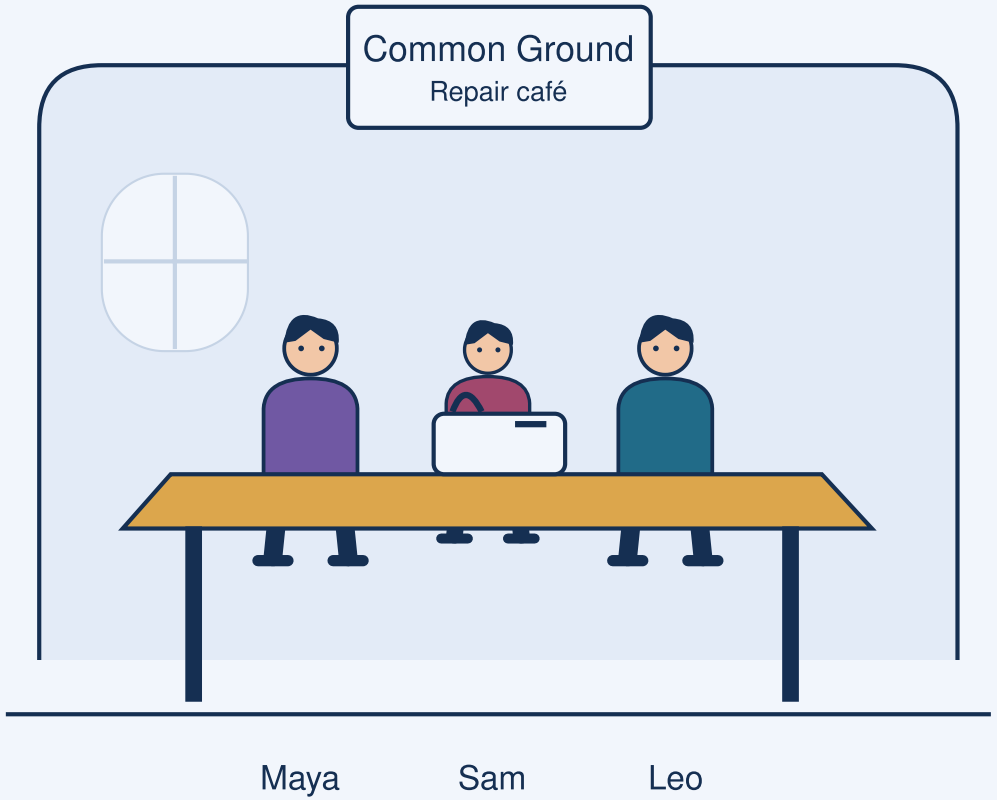


Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 6 · Story

Two invitations. Different reasons to care.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The invitation · c06s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

A prospect worries about time. What helps most?

A A second celebrity endorsement.

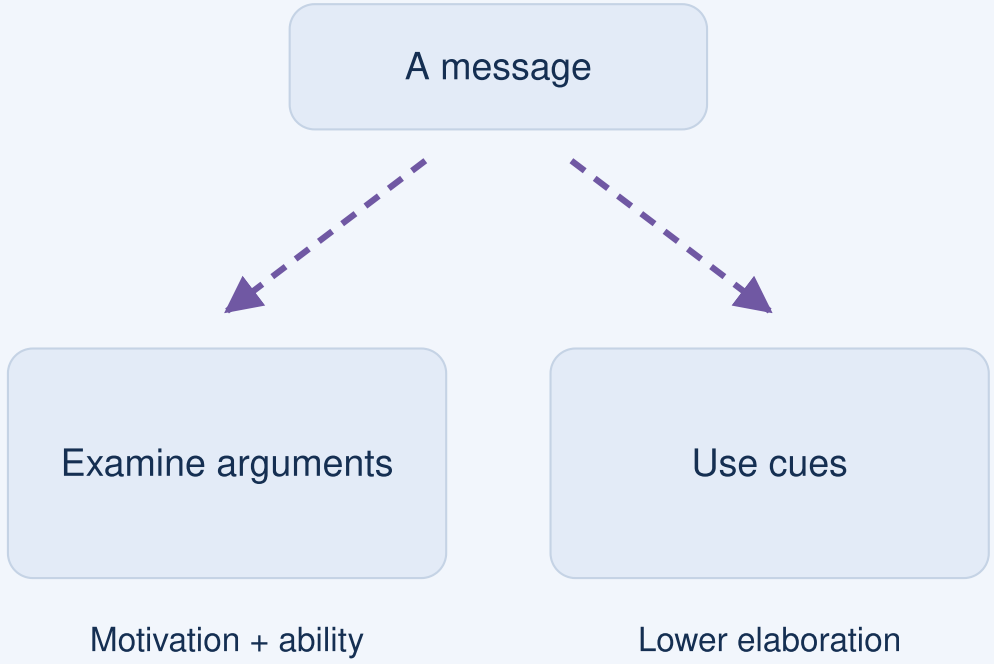
B Shift length, support, and an optional trial.

C A stronger claim that this is unmissable.

Suggested answer: B. Relevant details allow evaluation of the actual commitment.

Attention and evaluation are different jobs.

- Attitude: an evaluation of something.
- Central route: examine relevant arguments.
- Peripheral route: rely more on cues.

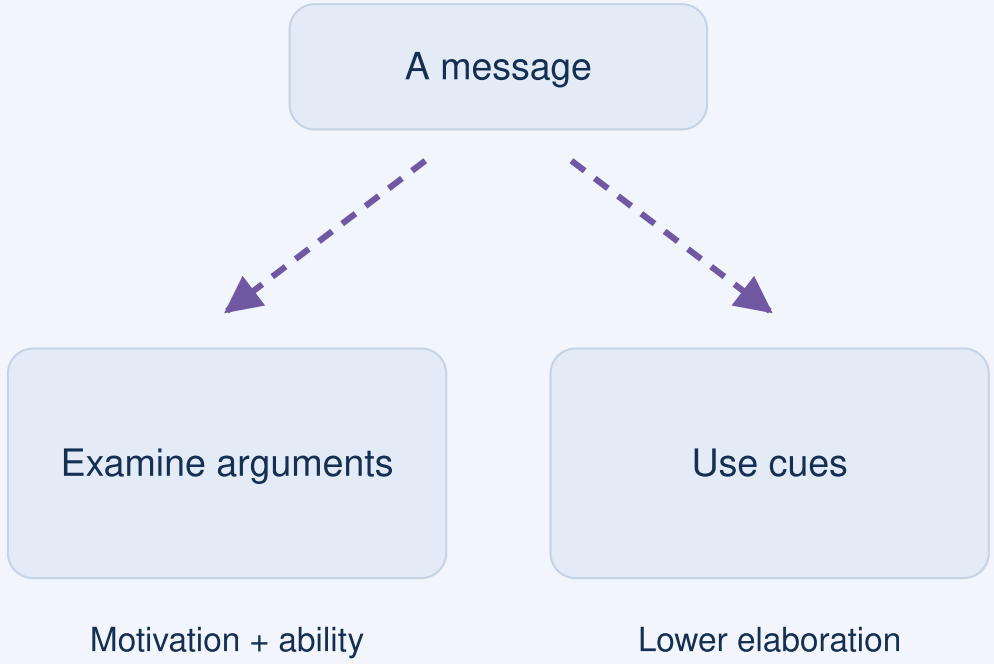


Processing changes with the decision.

Argument evaluation and cue use vary with motivation and ability.

A norm must be true to be useful.

- Descriptive: what people do.
- Injunctive: what people approve.
- A clear request needs an easy next step.

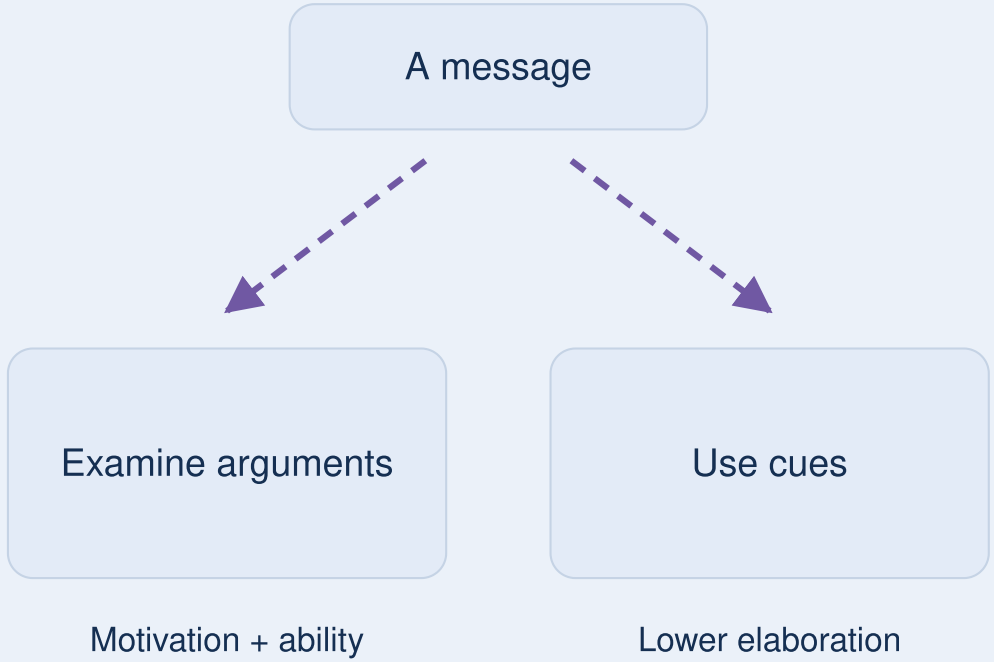


Processing changes with the decision.

Argument evaluation and cue use vary with motivation and ability.

What can we really conclude?

Persuasion varies with audience, topic, source, and outcome. A changed survey answer is not sustained behavior change. These recommendations are design hypotheses to test, not guaranteed conversion techniques. Compare comprehension, informed sign-ups, and retention rather than counting clicks alone. Also ask whether people understood the commitment and felt able to decline it.



Processing changes with the decision.

Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Few residents currently volunteer. Which invitation is defensible?

A “Everyone here already volunteers.”

B “Hardly anyone helps—don’t be like them.”

C “Try a supported two-hour shift; here is what it involves.”

Suggested answer: C. It gives a concrete, checkable request. Its effect still needs evaluation.

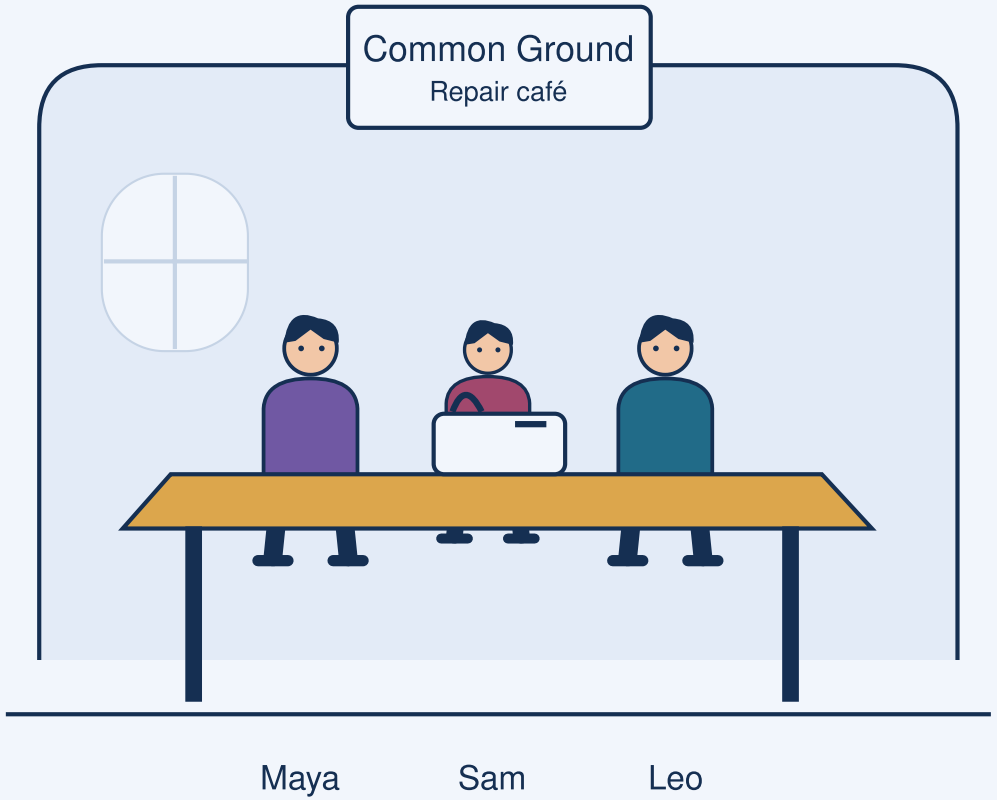
Close your notes. Explain it.

> What makes central processing more likely?

> Distinguish descriptive and injunctive norms.

1. Motivation, ability, attention, and relevant information.

2. Descriptive norms concern actions; injunctive norms concern approval.

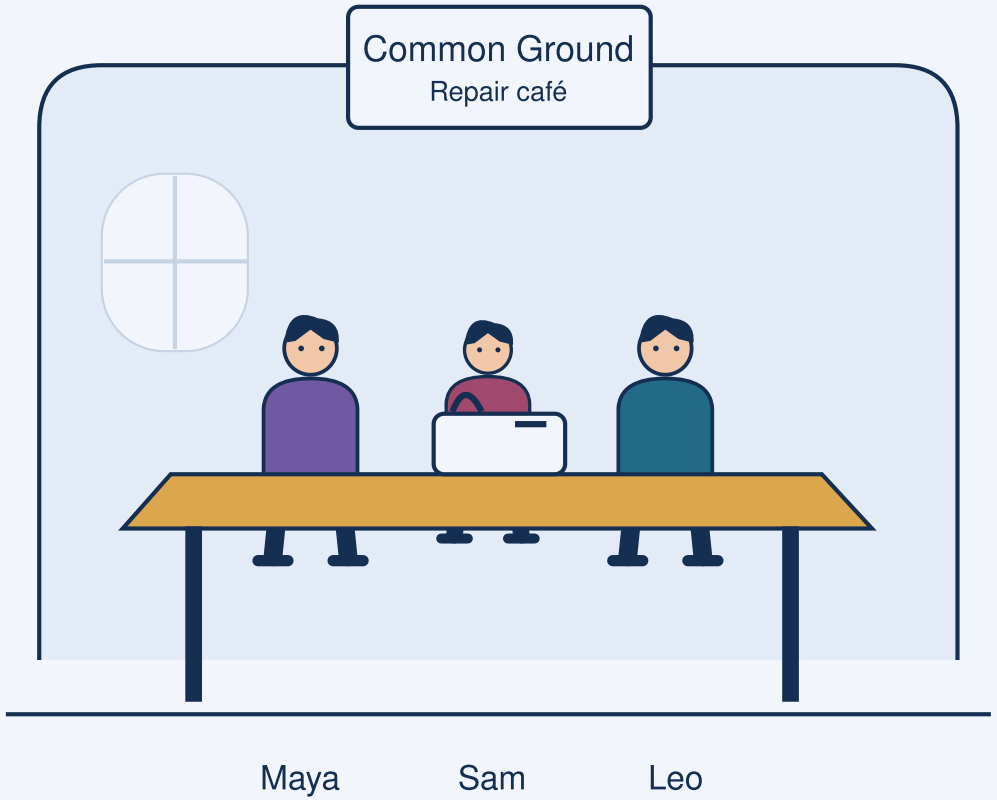


Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Rewrite a low-stakes invitation. State the decision, relevant reason, effort required, and next step. Remove social-proof claims you cannot substantiate.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.

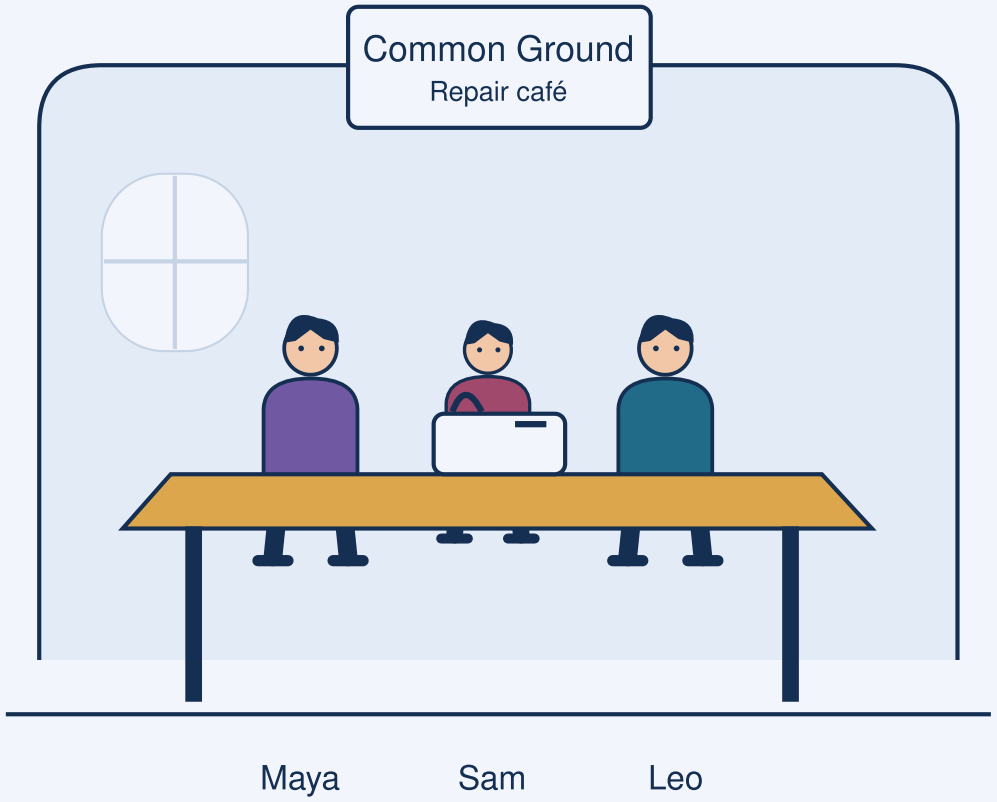


Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 7 · Story

Two teams stop sharing a table.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



When “we” takes over · c07s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

The shared checklist is unfinished. What is a useful first change?

A Agree on owners, deadlines, and needed support.

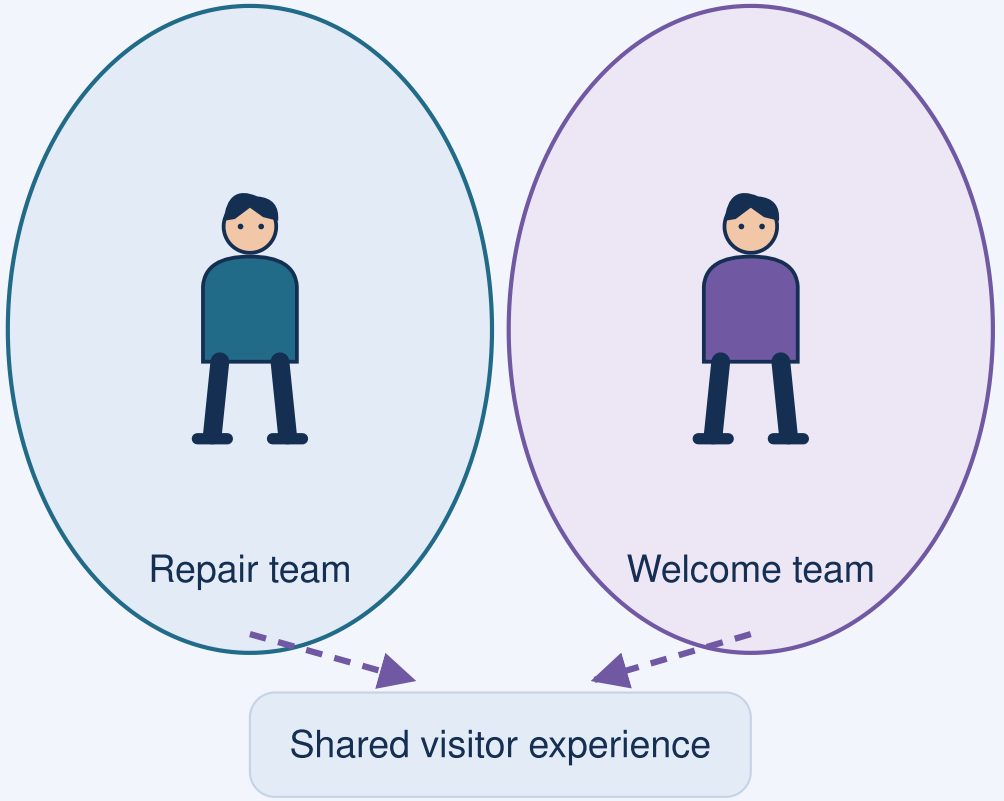
B Tell everyone their commitment is disappointing.

C Copy more people onto every task.

Suggested answer: A. This directly addresses responsibility and coordination.

Identity changes the boundary of “us.”

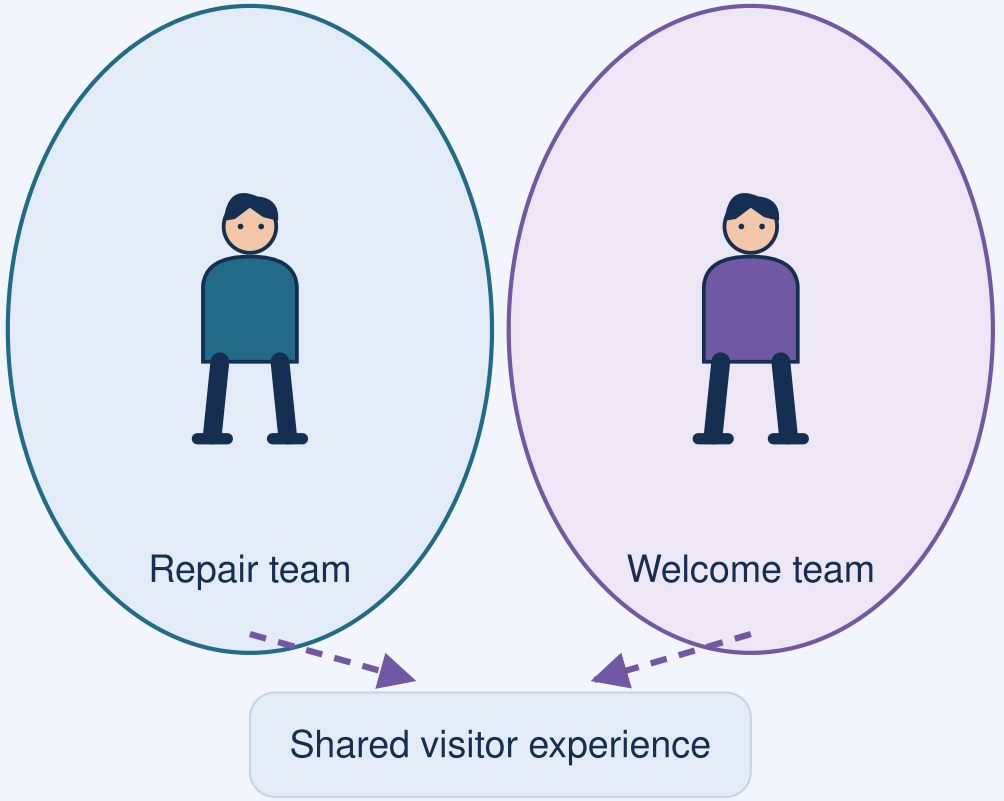
- Social identity: belonging shapes the self.
- In-group favoritism: favoring “our” side.
- Shared goals can widen the circle.



Separate teams can coordinate around a shared goal.

Groups can amplify—or lose—effort.

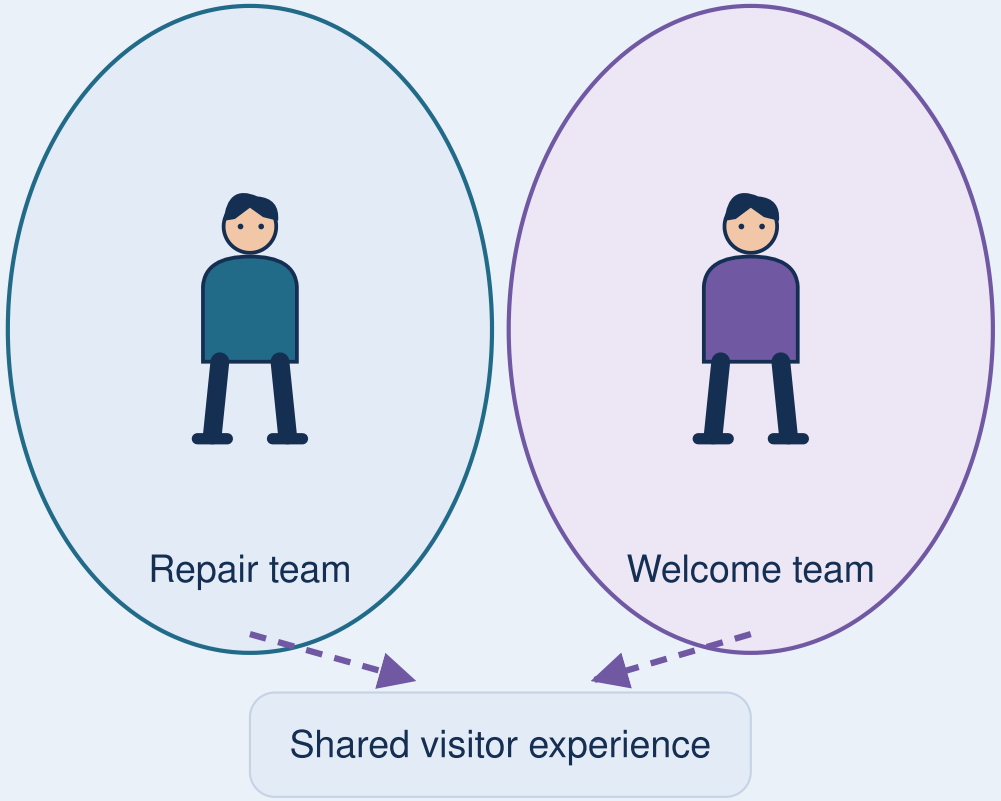
- Polarization: discussion can intensify an initial leaning.
- Social loafing: individual effort can fall in pooled work.
- Coordination loss: real effort is poorly combined.



Separate teams can coordinate around a shared goal.

What can we really conclude?

Groupthink is a label for some failures of critical discussion, not a complete explanation whenever a group makes a mistake. Seek observable processes: suppressed dissent, repeated information, incentives, effort, or coordination. Independent estimates, clear roles, and structured disagreement solve different problems. Avoid calling a group irrational without identifying what would improve its decisions.



Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

An event budget keeps escalating without checking demand. What helps?

A Ask members to show stronger enthusiasm.

B Gather independent estimates and contrary evidence.

C Open with the chair’s preferred budget.

Suggested answer: B. This introduces information beyond the existing enthusiasm.

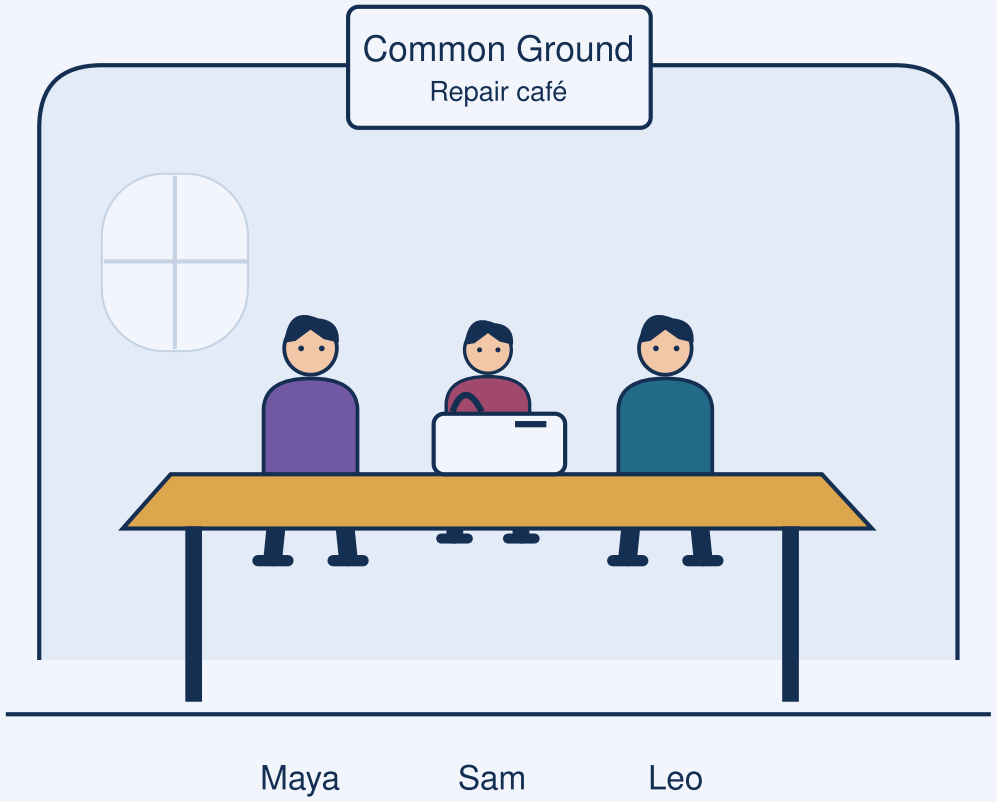
Close your notes. Explain it.

> How does polarization differ from consensus?

> How can a willing group still perform poorly?

1. Consensus is agreement; polarization moves toward a more extreme position from an initial leaning.

2. Poor sequencing, duplication, missing tools, or ambiguous roles can waste genuine effort.

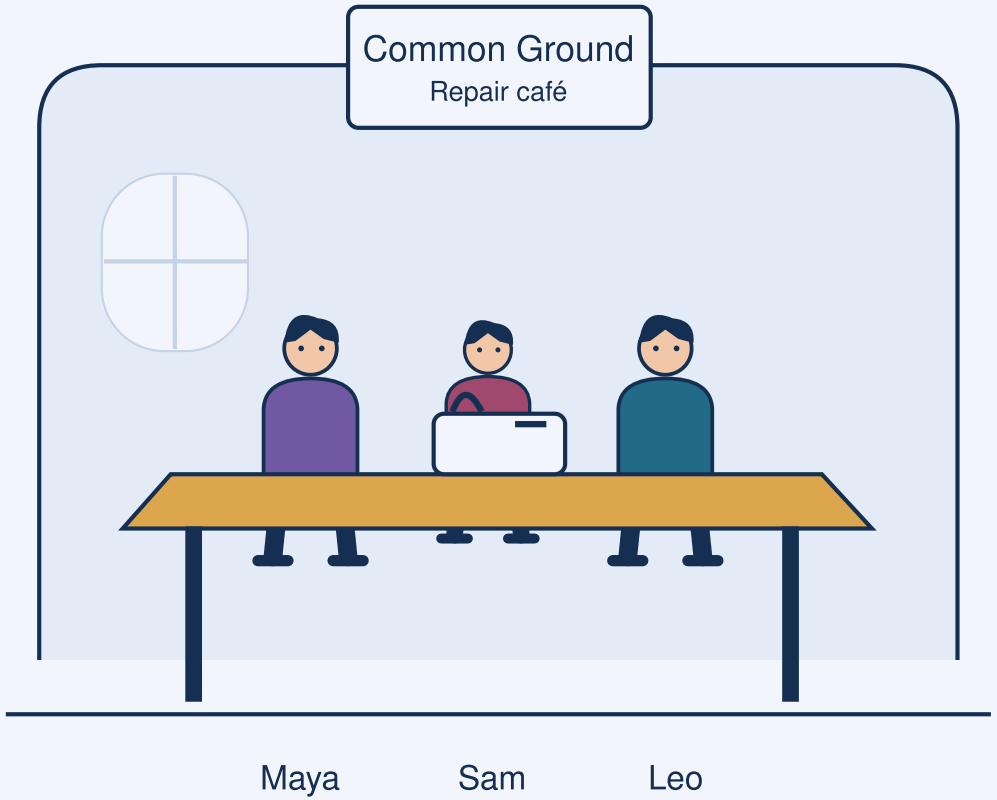


Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Map a shared project: task, owner, dependency, and feedback point. Decide whether its main obstacle is effort, coordination, or decision quality before proposing a remedy.

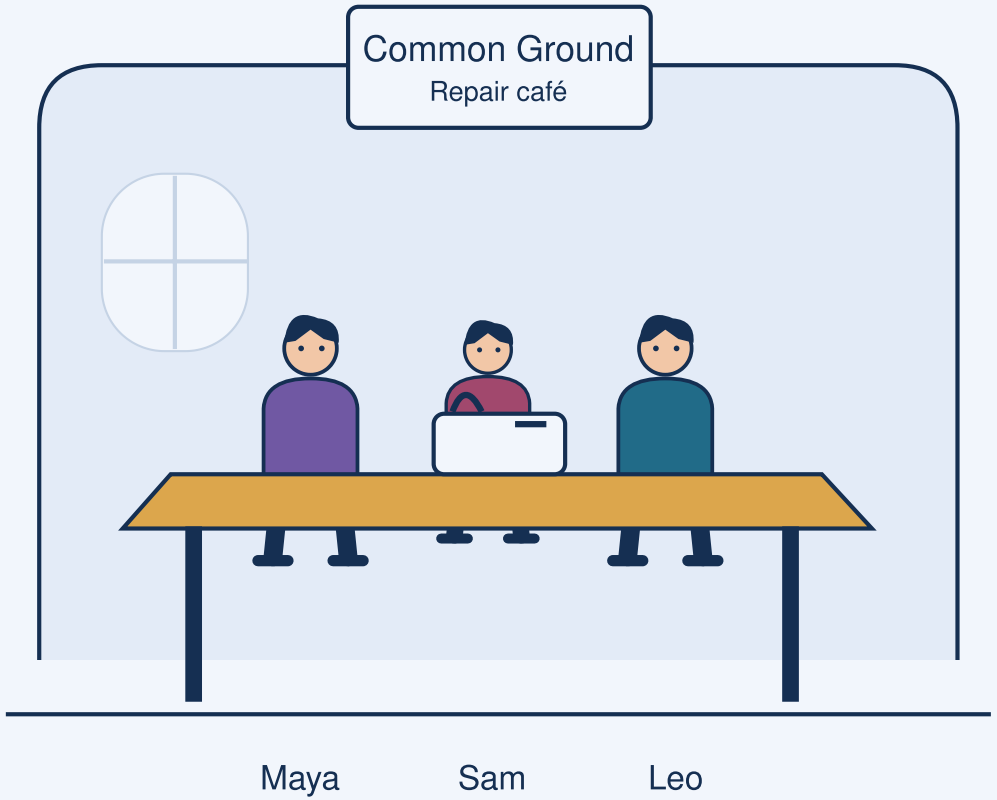
Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

“Anyone can join.” The form says otherwise.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

How should the team investigate unequal access?

A Ask whether organizers consider themselves fair.

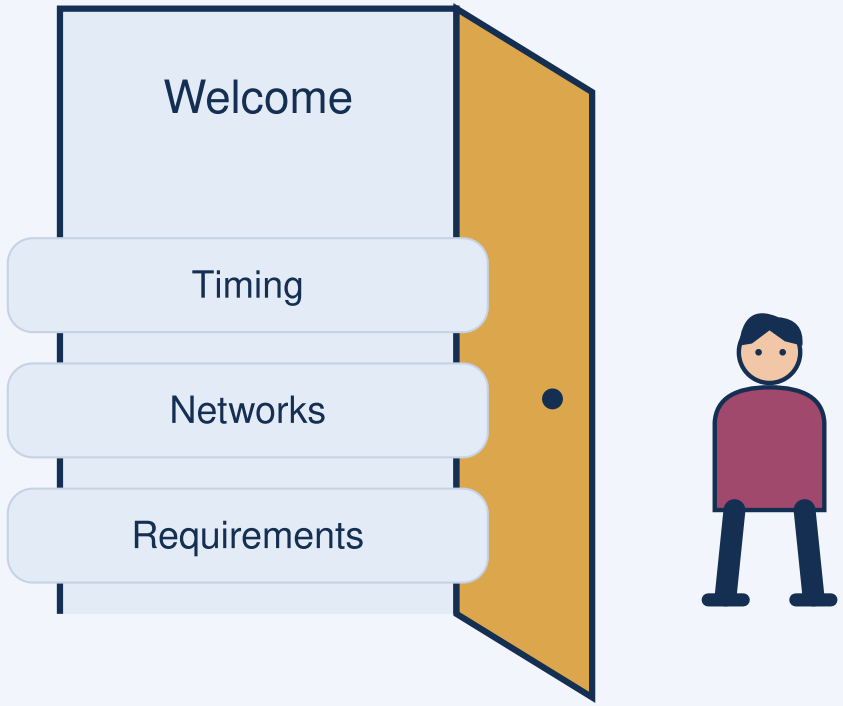
B Trace who can enter each stage and where people drop out.

C Add a fairness slogan to the poster.

Suggested answer: B. A process audit can reveal barriers that intentions and slogans miss.

Belief, feeling, and action are distinct.

- Stereotype: a generalized group belief.
- Prejudice: an evaluative attitude toward a group.
- Discrimination: unequal treatment based on group membership.

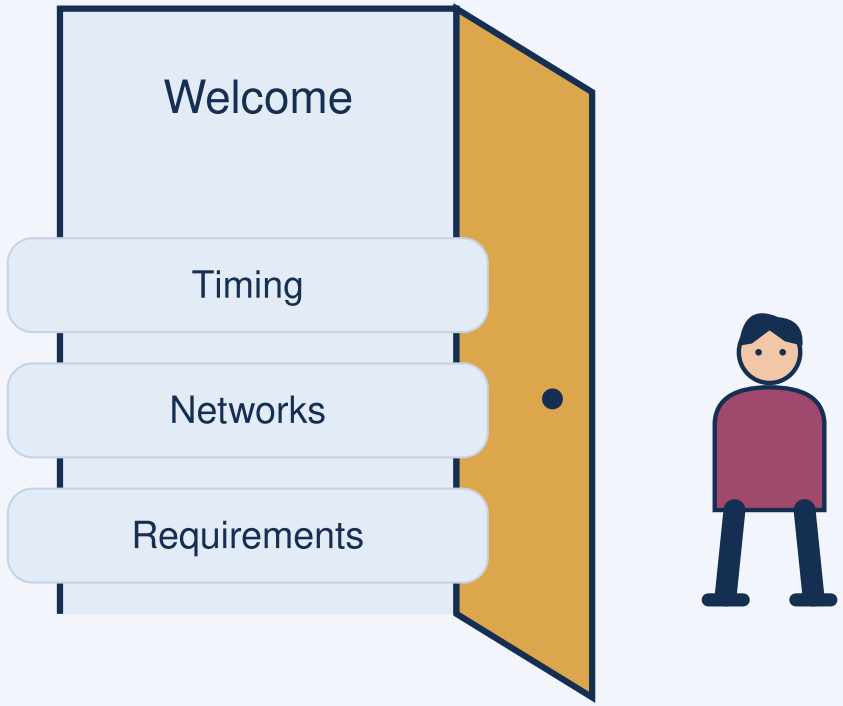


Good intentions do not remove every barrier.

Timing, networks, and requirements can restrict access.

Change the encounter and the structure.

- Use relevant, consistent criteria.
- Remove unnecessary access barriers.
- Support cooperation and meaningful participation.

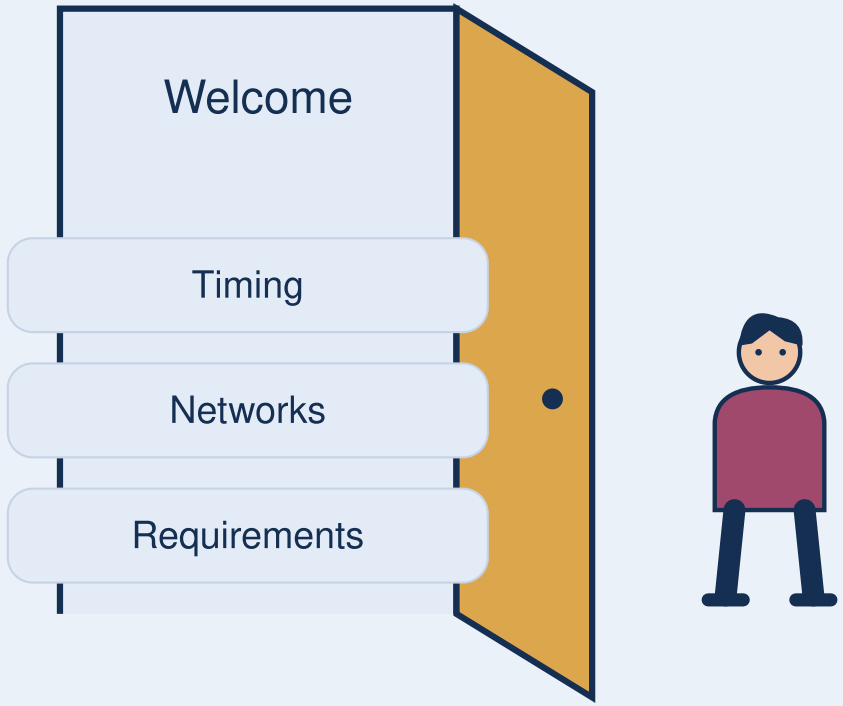


Good intentions do not remove every barrier.

Timing, networks, and requirements can restrict access.

What can we really conclude?

Explicit attitudes, implicit associations, and discriminatory behavior are different measures. A test score is not a complete character diagnosis or a forecast of every action. Evaluate interventions using meaningful behavior and access outcomes, follow-up, and affected people's experiences. Account for small samples and protect privacy; measuring inequality does not justify collecting unnecessary personal information.



Good intentions do not remove every barrier.

Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Friend referrals become an open skills-based application. How can improvement be assessed?

A Check whether organizers feel more inclusive.

B Compare the friendliness of form wording.

C Track applications, progression, and participation using relevant criteria.

Suggested answer: C. Stage-by-stage outcomes can reveal remaining barriers; interpret with context and privacy safeguards.

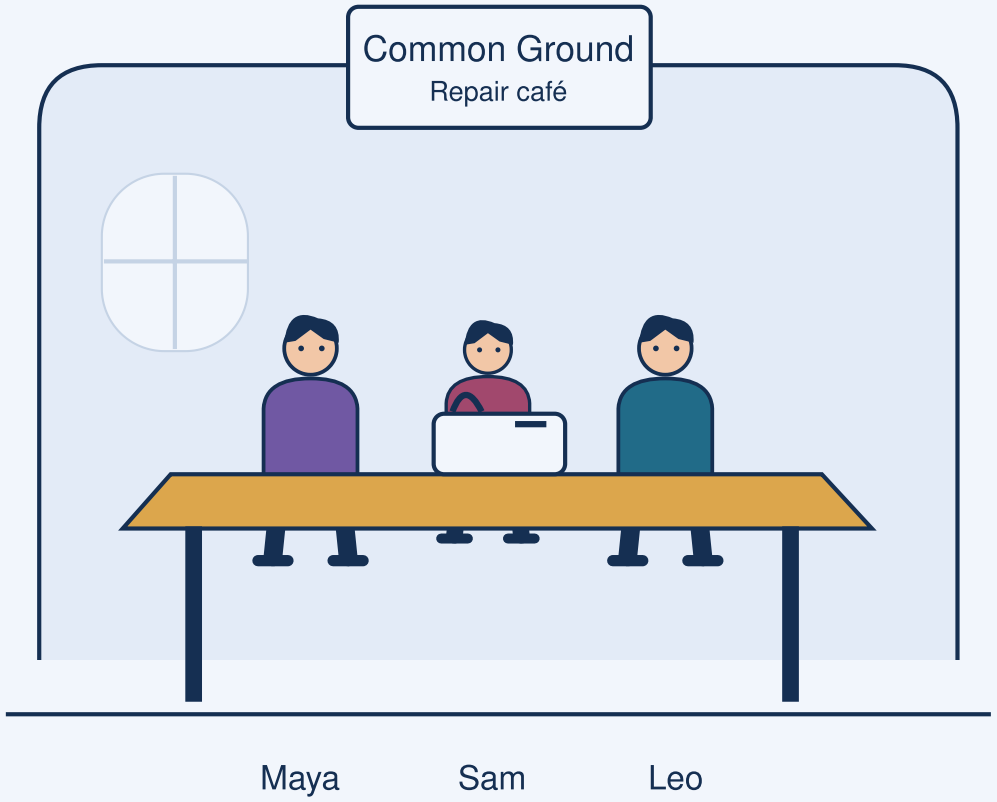
Close your notes. Explain it.

> Give discrimination without open hostility as an example.

> Why might a contact event leave unequal access unchanged?

1. An irrelevant requirement or restricted network can exclude a group without a hostile statement.

2. Power, incentives, status differences, or procedures may stay unchanged.

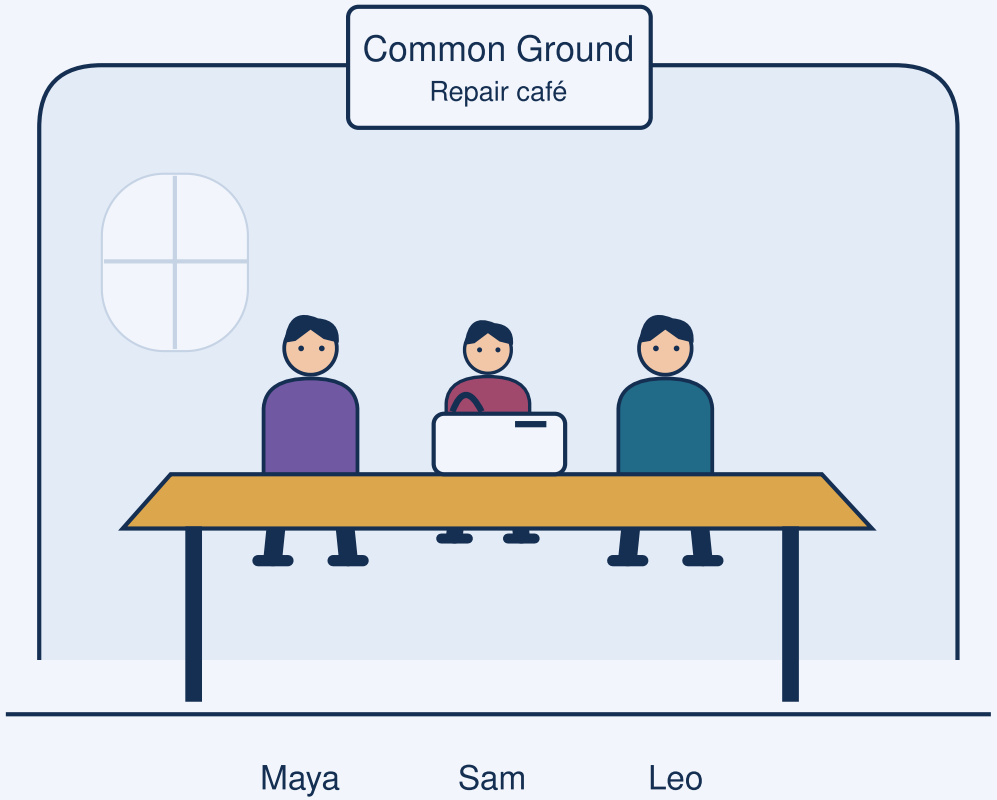


Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Review a process you are authorized to examine. Identify an unnecessary barrier, propose a change, and select a fair outcome measure without collecting unnecessary personal data.

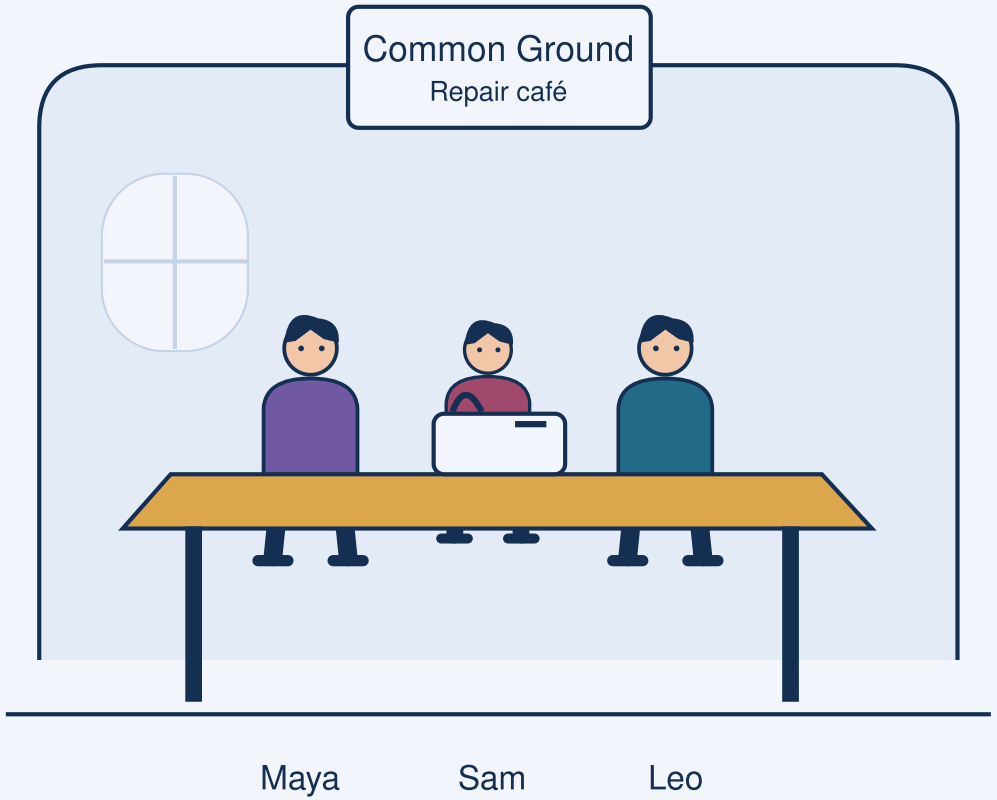
Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Friendship begins with the quiet shift.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

A newcomer hopes to make friends. What is a respectful starting point?

A Offer a shared activity and notice reciprocal interest.

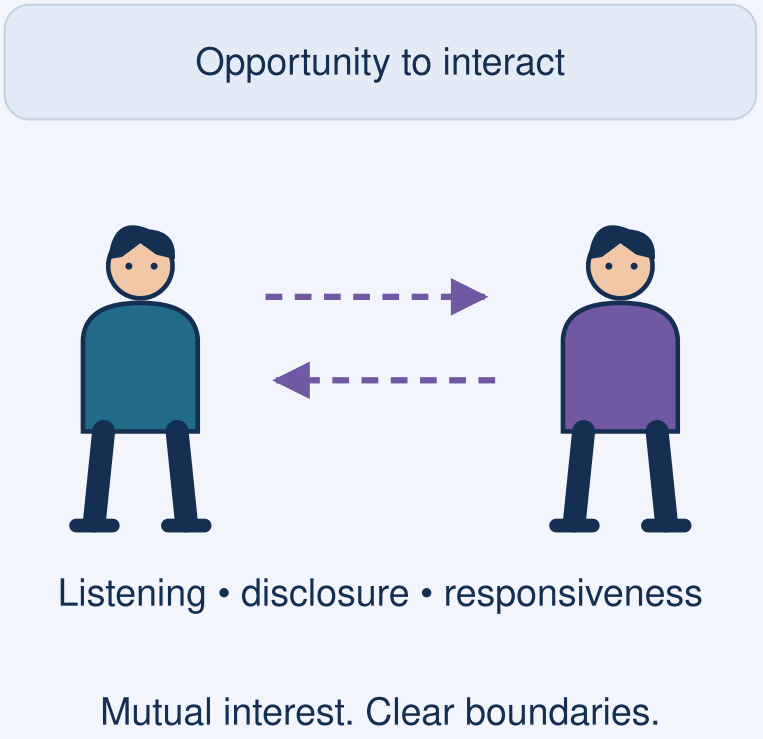
B Share increasingly private details until closeness develops.

C Keep arranging contact after invitations are declined.

Suggested answer: A. This creates an opportunity while preserving choice.

Opportunity shapes who becomes familiar.

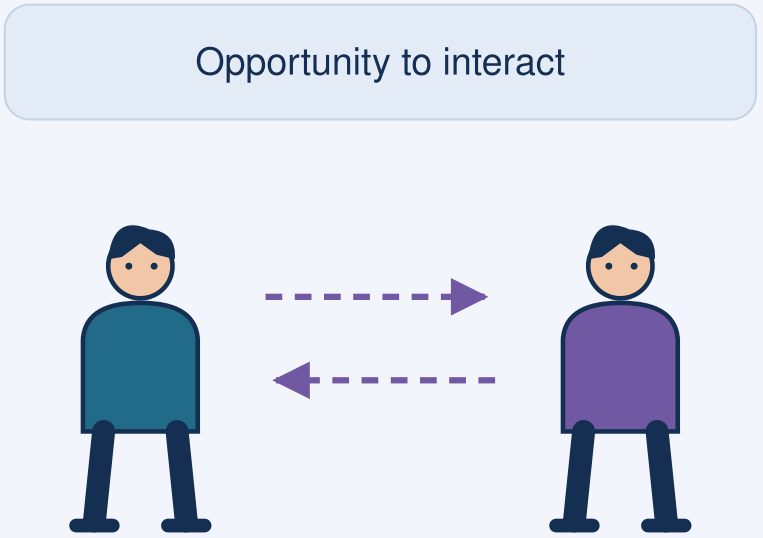
- Proximity creates opportunities to meet.
- Familiarity can increase liking in some conditions.
- Similarity can make interaction easier.



Connection depends on mutual responsiveness and boundaries.

Closeness is a reciprocal process.

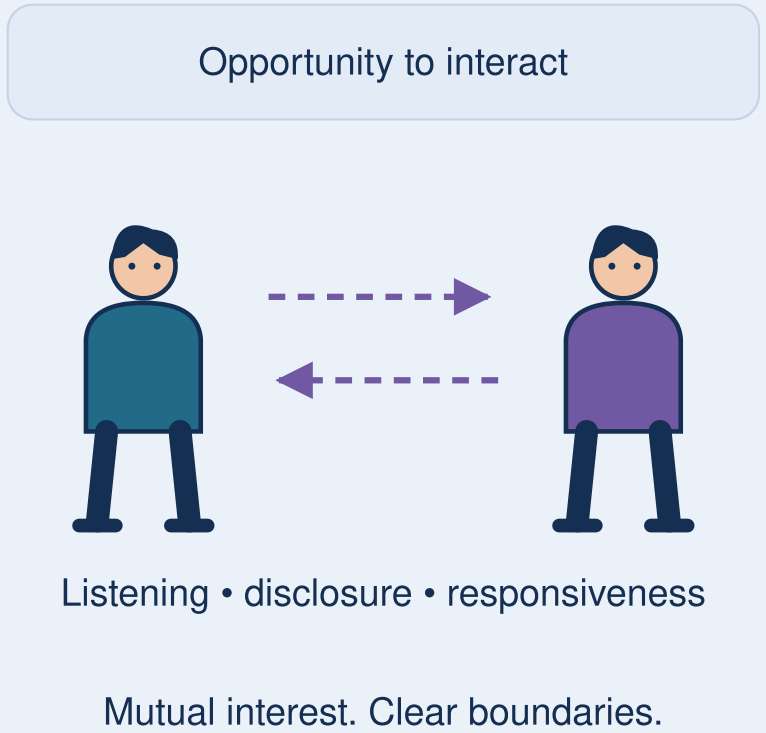
- Disclosure: sharing something personal.
- Responsiveness: feeling heard and understood.
- Boundaries: willingness is mutual and revisable.



Connection depends on mutual responsiveness and boundaries.

What can we really conclude?

Much relationship research is correlational or uses self-reports from particular cultures and relationship forms. An association between similarity and satisfaction does not prove that making two people more similar improves their relationship. Distinguish average associations from advice for a particular pair, and give direct communication more weight than catchy compatibility rules.



Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Sam declines an invitation and needs time alone. What should Leo do?

A Diagnose an avoidant attachment style.

B Accept the boundary and leave future contact optional.

C Increase contact to use the familiarity effect.

Suggested answer: B. This respects the stated preference without inventing a diagnosis.

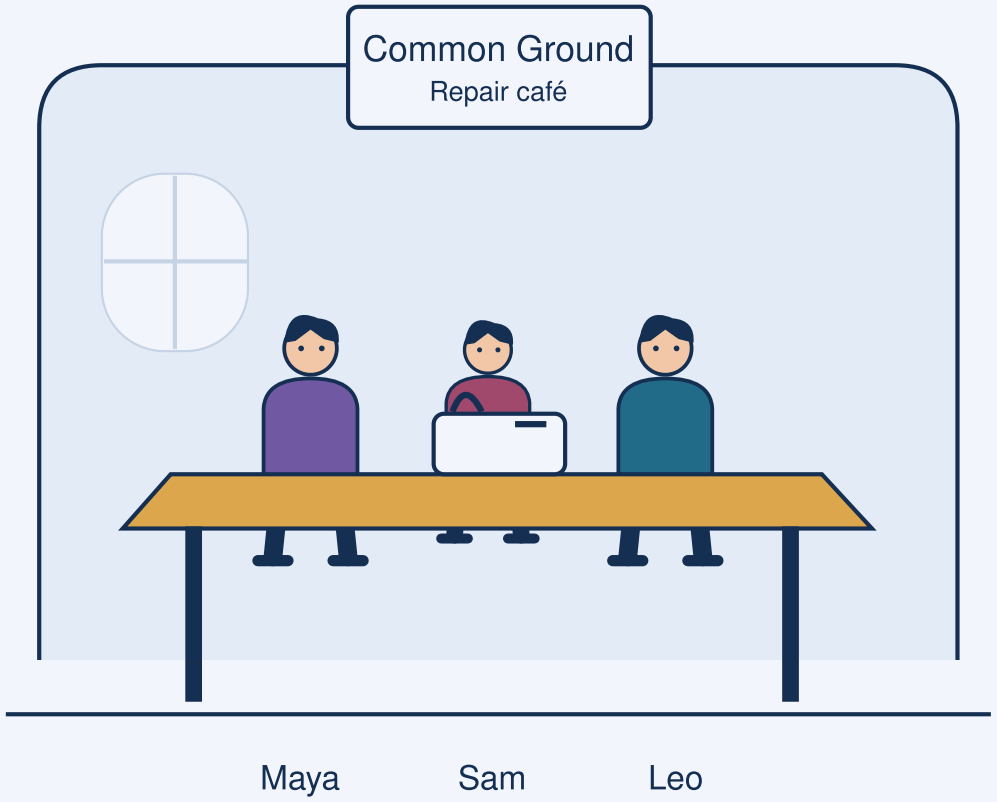
Close your notes. Explain it.

> How can proximity affect friendship?

> Why is disclosure alone insufficient?

1. It changes opportunities to interact and discover shared interests.

2. Willingness, response, trust, context, and mutual boundaries also matter.

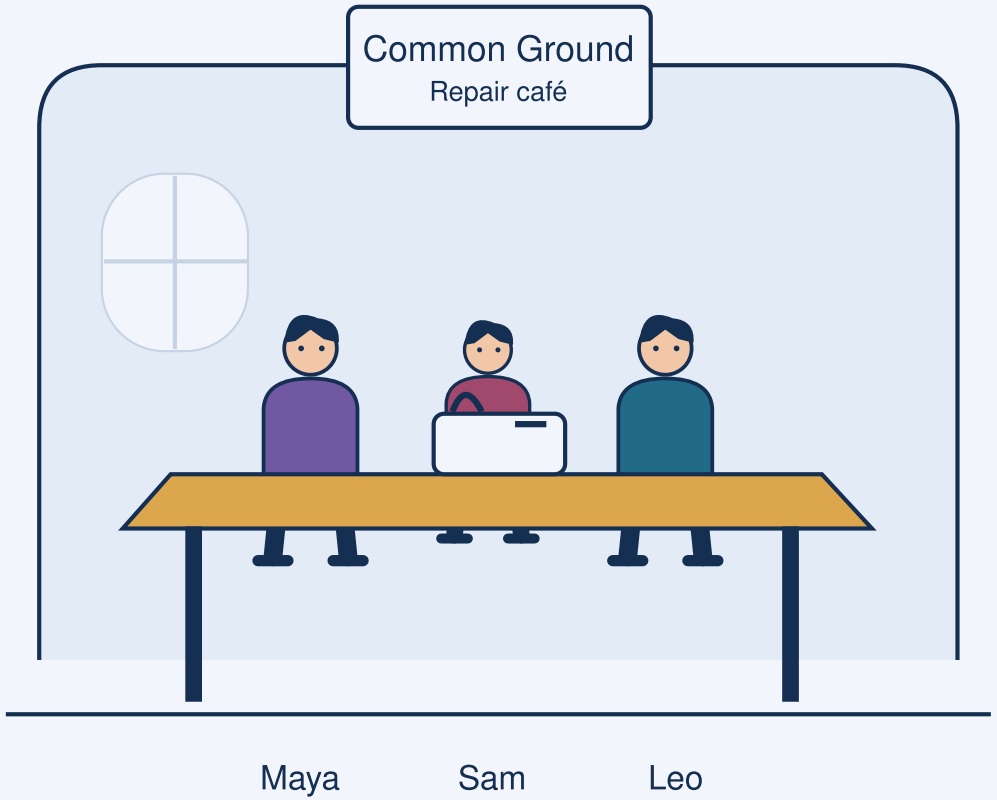


Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

In a willing everyday conversation, ask an open question and summarize what you heard before offering advice. Reflect on responsiveness rather than whether you won someone’s affection.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.

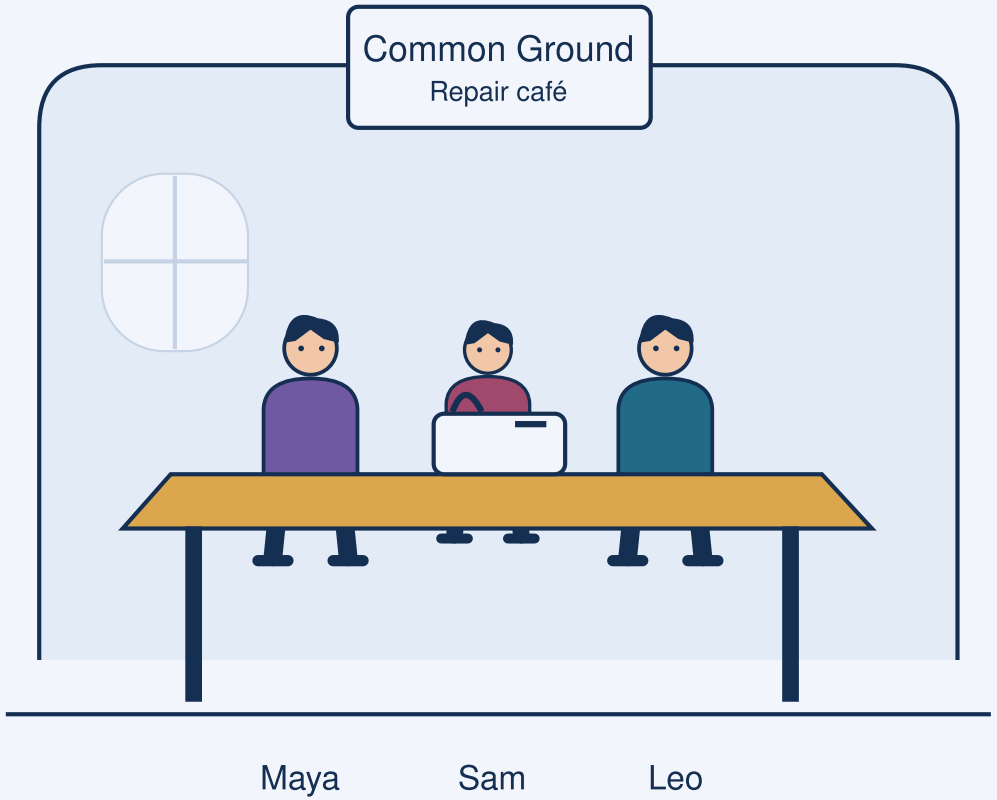


Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 10 · Story

A crash. A full room. A moment of hesitation.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



Who will do something? · c10s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

Why could concerned bystanders hesitate?

A Concern disappears when groups become large.

B People may be uncertain and assume someone else will act.

C Hesitation proves nobody cares.

Suggested answer: B. Ambiguity and divided responsibility can both contribute.

Helping has several decision points.

- Notice and interpret the need.
- Accept responsibility; identify a safe action.
- Act with available skills and support.



Helping involves noticing, interpreting, responsibility, and safe action.

Make constructive action easier.

- Aggression: behavior intended to harm.
- De-escalation: lower threat and preserve safety.
- Cooperation: align goals, roles, and feedback.



Helping involves noticing, interpreting, responsibility, and safe action.

What can we really conclude?

Laboratory aggression measures are imperfect proxies for serious violence. Bystander findings vary with danger, relationships, and available support. Avoid universal slogans about crowds. For real emergencies, follow local guidance and your training; a social psychology explanation does not replace first-aid instruction. Assess practical changes by whether appropriate, safe help becomes more available.



Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Which preparation makes future help more likely?

A Tell everyone to be more caring.

B Assume the most senior person handles all incidents.

C Agree on response roles, training, and a call-for-help route.

Suggested answer: C. Preparation addresses ability and responsibility, not just intentions.

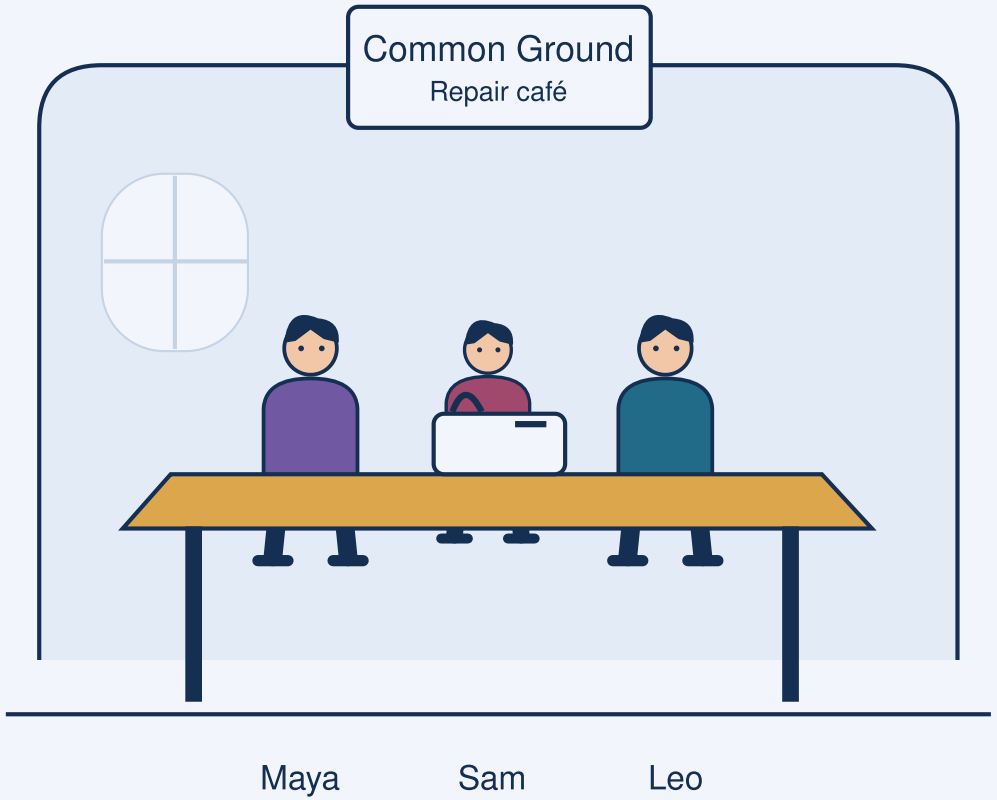
Close your notes. Explain it.

> Distinguish diffusion of responsibility from pluralistic ignorance.

> Apply two earlier chapters to an incident review.

1. Diffusion concerns who should act; pluralistic ignorance concerns interpreting others' reactions.

2. Separate observations from blame (1), compare causes (2), invite independent accounts (5), or assign clear roles (7).

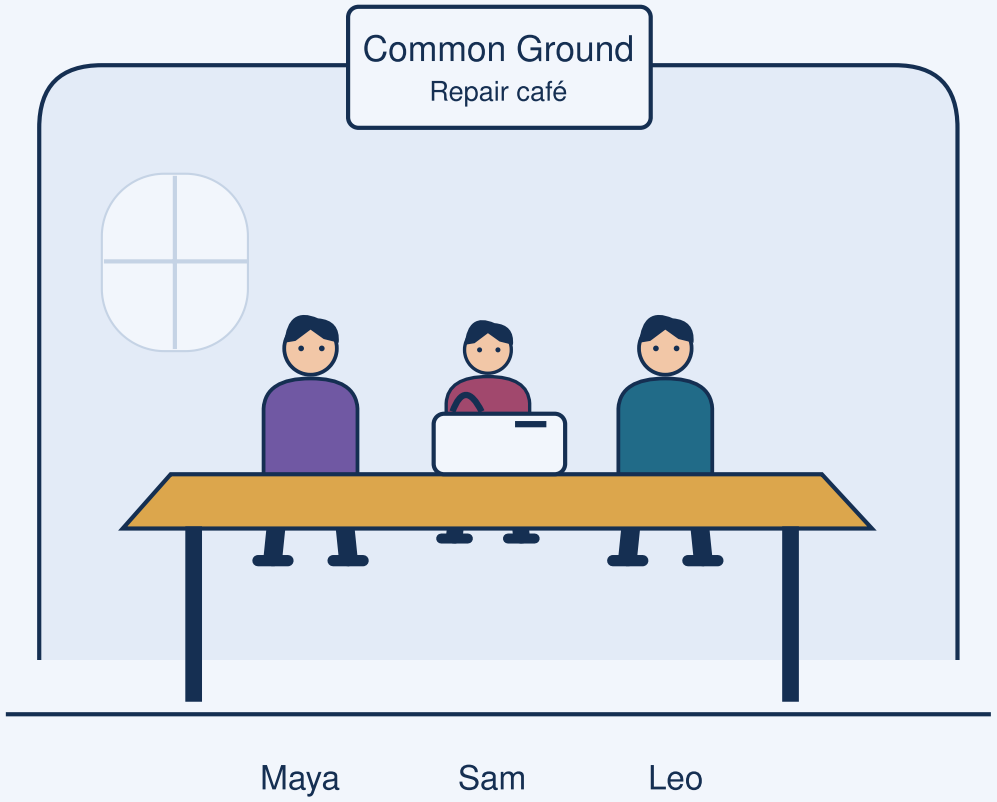


Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Design a helping plan for a low-risk shared task: signal, named role, safe action, and feedback. Explain how context, evidence, influence, and group structure shape your plan.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.